

Transmission of the *Milindapañha*

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This article re-examines speculations about school affiliation of the *Milindapañha* (*Questions of King Milinda*) and traces its presence from North West India in the early centuries CE up to Southeast Asia in the nineteenth century. As there are significant differences between the textual traditions of the Pali Text Society's *Milindapañho* and the Siamese printed edition, the *Milindapañhā*, I will discuss the little-known textual characteristics of the Siamese recensions which were circulating in Central Siam from at least the seventeenth century. This is possible with the discovery of several Ayutthaya period *Milindapañha* manuscripts kept at a temple and the National Library of Thailand. By the end of the eighteenth century, at least three different recensions were circulating in Central Siam. This paper will present some of their dissimilarities as well as their probable textual lineages. The newly discovered manuscripts also partly demonstrate that the shape of the textual tradition of a text, at least for the *Milindapañha* in Siam, reflects a function of the textual community that preserved and transmitted it.

Introduction

Scholars have long been intrigued by the origin and school affiliation of the *Milindapañha*. Our understanding of the text's transmission is limited by the fact that it is extant only in the Pāli and Chinese traditions. However, as we shall see, there are increasing findings on the Milinda¹-Nāgasena tradition that do not fit into the two surviving recensions. Thus, this raises the question as to whether the Milinda-Nāgasena tradition was more popular than is usually considered to be the case. Furthermore, even within the Pāli tradition, the text exhibits different textual characteristics. Numerous scholarly contributions have pointed out discrepancies between the textual tradition of the Pali Text Society's *Milindapañho* edited by Trenckner (Trenckner 1880, hereafter Mil) and the Siamese or Thai

1. I use Milinda, the Pāli name here instead of Menander for easy reference.

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printed edition, *Milindapañhā* edited by Chattasalla Thera (Chattasalla Thera et al. 1923: hereafter Si).² Little is known as to how these discrepancies came to be. Some editors have even brushed aside Si as an inflated and unreliable text that is filled with spurious supplements (Trenckner 1880, v; Vadekar 1940, vii). However, it is evident that Mil and Si are based on different textual traditions. Among the early comparative studies between the two Pāli editions, some are brief and cover just the first three parts of the text and not the rest.³

In order to understand why and how the differences came to be, I have traced the transmission history of the Siamese *Milindapañhā* by examining the manuscripts that circulated in Central Siam.⁴ So far, we have found two recensions, *Chabap Ayutthaya* (CA) and *Chabap Lamphun* (CL), both of which circulated in Central Siam since the late Ayutthaya period (~1650–1767) if not earlier. Another recension, *Chabap Krung Thep* (CKT), comes into the picture around the First Reign of the Rattanakosin era (1782–1809); it evolved from CA and includes certain materials from CL. Each of the three differ in their structures and textual traditions. Moreover, there are some manuscripts that I call the hybrid recension, which display the textual characteristics of the other recensions, especially CA and CL. None of these recensions have been studied in detail before.

In the first part of this article, I will discuss the various ideas about the school (*nikāya*) affiliation of this text and then track its transmission through various locations from North West India, China and Ceylon to Southeast Asia, based on archaeological and textual evidence. I include a provisional chronology of the text (Appendix I). In the second part, I will focus on the transmission of the text in Siam, from the Ayutthaya period to the Rattanakosin era, by examining its textual traditions and how intertextual influences resulted in a new recension (CKT). I will also give a brief outline of the frameworks of the various textual traditions and will compare them with other known recensions, discussing some differences in important details, such as the matter of nuns with permanent addresses and the frequency of meals the Buddha partakes of in a day. I will also touch on dialogues found only in the Siamese text like the “Question on Going to the World Beyond” and the disparities in a section of the *Anumānapañhā* (“Questions [solved by] Inference”). Lastly, despite lack of evidence in their textual lineages, I will put forth some hypotheses about the potential origins of the Siamese recensions. This analysis has been possible with access to the numerous *Milindapañhā* manuscripts kept at the National Library of Thailand,⁵ some dated to the late Ayutthaya period, as well as certain manuscripts found at Samuh Nimit temple in Southern Siam.

2. Mizuno 1959, 37–40; Thich Minh Chau 1964, 226–227; Skilling 2010, 1–24.

3. Corresponding to 1–89 of 420 pages of Mil; 1–132 of 534 pages of Si.

4. Central Siam here covers an area bordered to the North by the Lan Na Kingdom, to the North-East and East by the Lan Sang Kingdom and Cambodia, and to the South in the peninsula by the Malay States.

5. There are seventy Pāli *Milindapañhā* and eighteen related manuscripts kept at the National Library of Thailand. For a brief catalogue, see Ooi 2021, 169–210.

In this article, I do not compare in any systematic detail the Chinese **Nāgasena Bhikṣu Sūtra* (*Nàxiān bǐqiū jīng* 那先比丘經: hereafter NBS), which corresponds to slightly more than one-fifth of the Pāli text,⁶ except on some important details. The NBS and its parallel in Pāli have been well studied for over a hundred years, leaving the rest neglected. I also do not compare in any detail Sinhalese or Burmese manuscripts, as my primary aim is to examine the Siamese manuscripts. Following more in-depth study of these important manuscripts, I hope comparison with other manuscript lineages will be more fruitful.

The source of the text

The *Milindapañha* presents itself as a series of dialogues between a Bactrian Greek ruler, King Milinda (Menander I, r. 155/165–130 BCE) and a Buddhist monk, Nāgasena. The exchanges purportedly took place at Sāgala (Eastern Punjab). The text was written down approximately a century later around the beginning of the first millennium (Mendis 1993, 2) by one or more unknown authors likely in North West India, and most probably in Gāndhārī (Salomon 2018, 26). Based on epigraphic and onomastic data, Baums suggests that the *Milindapañha* was composed with the intention to convert an audience beyond the Indians or Greeks, perhaps the cosmopolitan inhabitants of Gandhāra. It is Indianized enough in its literary form, as well as Hellenized enough to be persuasive for those versed in a Greek style of argumentation (Baums 2018, 42).⁷

The text in its original language has been lost or is yet to be found. Moreover, no other version is available in any Middle Indic languages except Pāli. The earliest known transmission of the *Milindapañha* can be traced to a Chinese translation, NBS, which is listed in the Catalogue of the Eastern Jin Dynasty (317–420 CE).⁸ Based on its technical terms, Japanese scholar Kogen Mizuno estimates that the *Milindapañha* was translated into Chinese around the second century CE, either at the time of Ān Shīgāo or a little earlier (Mizuno 1959, 30–32; Guan Xing 2008b, 237). This Chinese text corresponds to the first part of the Pāli *Milindapañha*, amounting to approximately one-fifth of the text. It is complete in itself, while not including sections like the *Meṇḍakapañha* (the “Dilemmas”), *Anumānapañha* (“Questions [solved by] Inference”) and *Opammakathāpañha* (“Questions on Talk of Similes”).

Some scholars have inferred that the original *Milindapañha* was shorter than the extant Pāli version, and the rest was added in Ceylon perhaps before or during the period of commentaries (*aṭṭhakathā*) (Geiger 1943 [2012], 27; von Hinüber 1996, 85–86). The fifth century commentator Buddhaghosa quoted the *Milindapañha* in his *Vinaya* commentary as *meṇḍaka-milindapañhesu* (Sp IV 742.27). This indicates that the other part of the text, the *Meṇḍakapañha* was already in circulation by then. Moreover, the Milinda-Nāgasena dialogues are cited in numerous commentaries to the Pāli *Tripitaka*, which are believed to have been composed around 370–450 CE

6. See n.3.

7. For further discussion on the history of the *Milindapañha* and its possible Greek and Indian influences, see Fussman 1993, 61–138.

8. Guan Xing trans. 2008a, 9, n.2.

(Table 3.2 in Gornall 2020, 41–42). Based on these short accounts, the composition of the *Milindapañha* would have more or less taken its final form, as defined by the scope of its surviving Pāli recension, by the fifth century, and thereafter was preserved and transmitted.

School affiliation

There have been suggestions that the text, in part or in whole, may derive from a tradition other than that of the Theravaṃsa school. Horner hypothesized, based on a number of citations in the *Milindapañha* which cannot be traced elsewhere in the Pāli canon, that these come from other literature, for example, that of the Sarvāstivāda (Horner 1963, xvii). For instance, there is at least one reference to a non-Theravāda dogma—space as an unconditioned dharma (*asaṃkṛta* dharma).⁹ Based on the lineage of teachers quoted by Yaśomitra, Dutt also attributes the *Milindapañha* to the Sarvāstivāda (Dutt 1978, 135). Bodhi, however, argued that the untraceable quotations, while puzzling, are not compelling evidence that the *Milindapañha* originated in a non-Theravaṃsa school. He points out that the *Nettipakaraṇa*, a work, in his opinion, of indubitable Theravaṃsa origin, contains several quotes that are also not found in the Pāli canon (Bodhi as cited in Mendis 1993, 13). The point is that the *Milindapañha* drew some of its citations from canon(s) that differed from today's received Theravāda canon. What does this mean? What was the original language of the quotes? Was it Pāli, a related Prakrit, or Gāndhārī? Or is the *Milindapañha* non-sectarian? Did the author(s) draw on the canons of several schools? Nāgasena, whether a historical or a literary figure, must have either himself had or been created by someone from a *vinaya* lineage, but we do not know which one. Presumably, Milinda as an ideal king should be impartial.

Skilling hypothesizes that the Milinda-Nāgasena dialogues were unaffiliated or independent texts (oral and written),¹⁰ which circulated in India and were later adopted and edited by different textual communities belonging to different schools.¹¹ As we shall see later, some Milinda-Nāgasena dialogues preserved in other languages are not represented in the Pāli *Milindapañha*. These Milinda-Nāgasena texts may have been transmitted within the various communities of Buddhist schools, and at a certain point those communities had to edit the texts for consistency with their respective textual traditions. For example, the texts may not have been received and transmitted, either as a single collection or separately, within monastic networks, and moved from North West Indian monastic communities to South India and the island of Tambapaṇṇa (Ceylon).¹² Along the way, some

9. Mil 268–271; Horner trans. 1969, 86–90 and n.5 at 86; Lamotte 1988, trans. Webb-Boin: 609–610.

10. Skilling 2020, in the article *Milinda Paradigm* (draft): email 29 July 2020.

11. The understanding of textual communities here is as outlined by Skilling: “Texts are written for and appeal to textual communities, meaning historical intellectual groups drawn together by shared ideas and ideals. The textual community shares in the preservation, transmission and interpretation of the text” (email 27 August 2021). It can refer to a particular lineage or school, or lines or theories of interpretation that have evolved out from earlier lineages and function independently.

12. For example, Cousins and Wynne argue that the Vibhajjavādin Theriyas, which later evolved

degree of editing and collating would have occurred. However, this textual editing may not have been entirely complete to be consistent with the received Pāli canon as we know it today. As such, this may explain why certain quotations in the *Milindapañha*, including the numerous verses found in the last part of the text, the *Opammakathāpañha* (“Questions on Talk of Similes”), are not traceable to the Pāli collections (Horner 1969, 228–303). The *Milindapañha* as we know it, may be only a fragment of what was a much wider Milinda-Nāgasena tradition.

Transmission of the *Milindapañha*

The Pāli *Milindapañha* may have gone through an uninterrupted transmission since it was first written down. But whether this text was transmitted orally, for example by using the *bhāṇaka* system, is difficult to ascertain. The text may have been transmitted from written to oral and then back to written form. For example, in the colophon of a Burmese-script printed edition of the *Milindapañha*, it is stated that the text was well arranged according to what was heard (*suṭṭhapitaṃ yathāsutaṃ*) by a monk named Thera Doṇi.¹³ This could mean either the monk dictated and a scribe copied it down, or the monk wrote it down from his own memory. Therefore, a certain level of oral transmission was being practiced with regard to this text.

In South and East Asia

There is little information about the transmission of the *Milindapañha* in the early centuries of the first millennium in India. Based on the assumption that the text originated in the Gandhāra region, it would have spread southwards across the Indian Peninsula, perhaps passing through Magadha and Āndhradeśa before arriving in Ceylon. The text also moved northwards into Central Asia and to China. It was later found transmitted to Southeast Asia as well.

Ceylon

By the third century CE, the *Milindapañha* was quoted in Ceylon’s Mahāvihāra old commentary or the *Mahāṭṭhakathā*.¹⁴ There are two passages in the *Aṭṭhasālīnī* (*The Expositor*), a commentary on the first book of the *Abhidhamma Piṭaka*, the *Dhammasaṅgaṇī*, taken from the *Mahāṭṭhakathā* which in turn quotes from the *Milindapañha*. One passage on the distinguishing mark of concentration that reproduces the simile of a ridge-pole (Si 55; Mil 38; Horner 1963, 52) is quoted directly but without mentioning the name Milinda or Nāgasena. The second passage is quoted indirectly, rephrased from the same dialogue, on the simile of a king going to a bat-

into separate schools, formed a network (likely post-Mauryan around the first century BCE until at least the third century CE) through their monastic lineages wherein literature was shared. See Cousins 2001, 131–132; Wynne 2018, 252.

13. Kobakyaw ed. 1919, 367; the same colophon was adopted by the *Chaṭṭhasaṅgīti* edition. See n.92.
14. Von Hinüber 1996, 152 §317; By the third century CE, the Mahāvihāra had formed its own commentarial collection—the *Mahāṭṭhakathā*, or the Great Commentary: see Cousins 2013/2014 (2015), 395.

tle but it is not rendered as a quotation (Si 55; Mil 38; Horner 1963, 52).¹⁵ Both are related to the notion of one-pointedness of mind (*cittekaggatā*) or concentration (*samādhi*) (As 118.16), addressed in the “Question on the Distinguishing Mark of Concentration” (*samādhilakkhaṇapañha*) in the *Milindapañha* (Si 55; Mil 38).¹⁶

The *Aṭṭhasālinī* is estimated to have been written during the era of the commentaries (c. late fourth to mid-fifth centuries). Its author, identified by the tradition as Buddhaghosa,¹⁷ also quotes directly several other passages from the *Milindapañha*, and in some instances specifically mentions the name “Nāgasena.” It is noteworthy here that Rhys Davids points out that the Milinda-Nāgasena dialogues that Buddhaghosa quotes in his works may not be the same recension as that used by Trenckner (Rhys Davids 1890, xiv–xvi). The *Milindapañha* passages in the *Sumaṅgalavilāsinī* (the commentary on the *Dīgha Nikāya*) and the *Manorathapūraṇī* (the commentary on the *Aṅguttara Nikāya*) present the same contents found in the Trenckner’s edition, but phrased differently. However, Rhys Davids held back from making any conclusion regarding this observation, suggesting that either Buddhaghosa reported the passages as he remembered or that he was referring to a recension which somewhat diverged from Trenckner’s. Moreover, whether Buddhaghosa saw the *Milindapañha* text(s) in India or Ceylon is difficult to ascertain.

Later, parts of the *Milindapañha* were quoted in the thirteenth or fourteenth century work, the *Sārasaṅgaha*, a comprehensive compendium of Buddhist doctrines compiled in the Pāli language by Siddhattha, at Dakkhinārāma in Polonnaruwa (Sāra vii–ix).¹⁸

Given the accounts above, the *Milindapañha* would have been transmitted to Ceylon by the third century CE, if not earlier, and was regarded as an authoritative text by the Mahāvihāra fraternity.

North India and China

In North West India, as mentioned earlier, a Milinda-Nāgasena dialogue text was translated into Chinese as the NBS, from an Indian dialect (Demiéville 1924, 21), probably North-Western Prakrit or Sanskrit (Guang Xing 2008b, 241). Two textual lineages coming from the same ancestor were preserved and transmitted separately. The first was translated by an unknown author around the second century CE, as estimated by Mizuno (1959). The second was translated by Guṇabhadra between 435 and 455 CE but the text has been lost since 664 CE (Demiéville 1924, 21). There are remarkable differences between NBS and the Pāli version, and NBS must have come from a different Middle Indic recension transmitted to China via Central Asia.¹⁹ There is no evident affiliation of NBS to any particular school. By the fourth to fifth centuries, it circulated in the Eastern Jin Dynasty territory (東晉).

15. Maung Tin trans. and Mrs Rhys Davids ed. & rev. 1976, 156 n.4 and n.5.

16. Mil does not have dialogue titles.

17. It could be anonymous. see Gornall 2020, Table 3.2 at 41–42.

18. However, the Siamese tradition reports that the author was Nanda, who composed the work in Siam: see Supaphan Na Bangchang [สุภาพรรณ ณ บางช้าง] 1990, 258–280.

19. Thich Minh Chau 1964; Guan Xing 2008b, 235–251; Demiéville 1924, 21–35; Mizuno 1959, 17–55.

Citations of Milinda-Nāgasena dialogues are found in other genres of texts. A dialogue between these two interlocutors is quoted in the *Abhidharmakośabhāṣya*, a treatise composed in Sanskrit around the fourth or fifth century CE by Vasubandhu (Pradhan 1967, 469).²⁰ The citation is found in the ninth *Kośasthāna* regarding the misconception about the person (*pudgala*). The king asks: “Is the life-force (*jīva*) the body or is the life-force one thing and the body another?”²¹ Nāgasena replies that this question cannot be answered and provides a simile asking whether a mango from a tree in the royal courtyard was sweet or sour when no such tree existed. There is no answer for such a question.

This *Abhidharmakośabhāṣya* passage is not found in either the Pāli recension or the Chinese NBS. However, Demiéville managed to trace a parallel in a Chinese *avadāna* (Demiéville 1924, 64–67). In this *avadāna*, the king is called Nanda (possibly from Menander) instead of Milinda.²² The parallel passage is close but there are some differences, for example, in the way the king poses the question. The *Kośabhāṣya*’s concern is *jīva* and the body, the Chinese concern is permanence and impermanence. Both use the same style of answering and the mango simile. Hence, the two may be associated but they came from different recensions of a further Milinda-Nāgasena tradition (Skilling 1998, 91).

A Chinese *avadāna* collection, the *Zábǎozàng jīng* (雜寶藏經), contains 121 *avadānas* translated by an Indian *śramaṇa*, *Kikkāya (吉迦夜) and a Chinese monk Tányào (曇曜) in 472 CE (Takakusu 1896, 17).²³ Willemsen points out that these stories might have come from regions of Gandhāra or Kashmir, a probable place of origin of the translator *Kikkāya who might have translated them from Sanskrit. He also attributes them to the Sarvāstivādins (Willemsen 1992, 507–515). The Nanda-Nāgasena dialogue in this collection is short and consists of a brief story of a proud king looking for a learned person to answer his questions. He meets an old monk (unnamed) before eventually coming face to face with Nāgasena. The king puts four to five questions to Nāgasena. This storyline is similar to the longer Pāli *Milindapañha*. When Demiéville compared the *avadāna* Nanda-Nāgasena dialogues to the Pāli *Milindapañha* and the Chinese NBS, he discovered that the contents are not found in the two longer recensions (Demiéville 1924, 64–67). This Nanda-Nāgasena dialogue must have been a text, perhaps part of a longer text, which circulated independently before it was picked up by the compilers, as a part or whole, to be included in this collection of *avadānas*.

Vasubandhu’s citation, albeit a short one, does not come from the recensions discussed above. We do not know exactly where he took the excerpt from. There could

20. The published edition of the Sanskrit text gives the name of the king as *Kaliṅga-rāja*. The two Chinese translations by Paramārtha and Zuanxang read Min-lin-to and Pi-lin-to respectively. For further discussion on the king’s name in the *Abhidharmakośabhāṣya*, see Skilling 1998, 81–101.

21. For an English translation of this passage, see Skilling 1998, 96–97.

22. Winternitz is of the opinion that the “Nanda” here is certainly only a Sanskrit version of the Greek Menandros: see Winternitz 1934 rev. 1983, 171.

23. The Nanda-Nāgasena dialogue can be found in the 111th story (the ninth chapter) of the *avadāna* 雜寶藏經 (T 203 [4] 492c24).

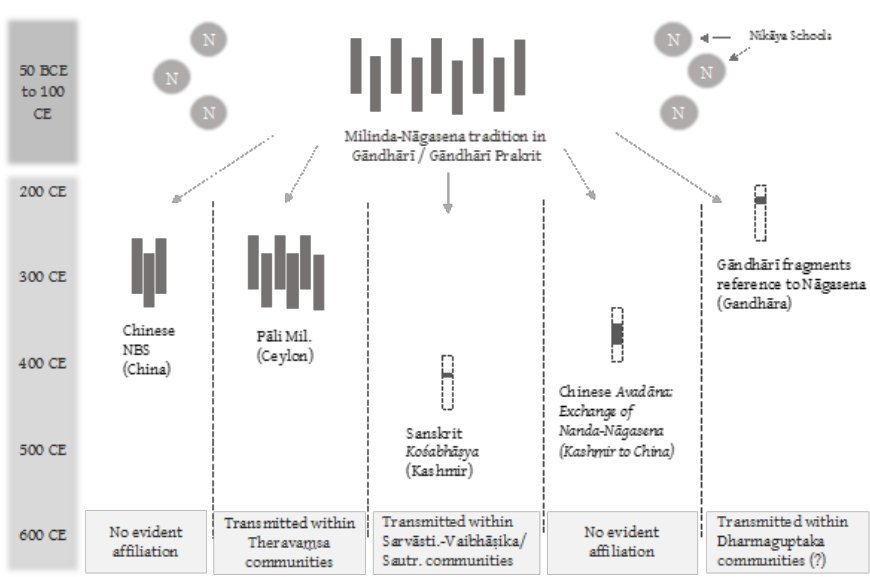


Figure 1 Transmission of unaffiliated Milinda-Nāgasena texts in early centuries CE. Figure adapted from Skilling 2020, *Milinda Paradigm* (draft) with permission: email 28 October 2020.

very well have been a Milinda-Nāgasena recension, perhaps in Sanskrit, transmitted within the Sarvāstivādin-Vaibhāṣika communities, which is no longer available to us today. Recently, Salomon wrote: “A few small fragments have been discovered of a Gandhāri text that has some resemblance to the *Questions of Milinda*, including a reference to Nāgasena, but they seem to belong to some related tradition rather than to the *Questions* itself” (Salomon 2018, 26).

From these examples, we can see that not all Milinda-Nāgasena dialogues are represented by the Pāli textual tradition; they also occur elsewhere. Perhaps it is time to move away from trying to fit all Milinda-Nāgasena related fragments or translations within the frame of the received Pāli text. The cognate of Milinda-Nāgasena texts could be, as argued by Skilling, autonomous or unaffiliated works that circulated independently and were later adopted and edited by various Buddhist schools (Figure 1).

Later, in the eleventh century, a Kashmiri poet, Kṣemendra, makes a short mention of King Milinda, in the *Stupāvadāna* of the *Bodhisattvāvadāna-Kalpalatā*, preserved in the Tanjur in transliterated Sanskrit with Tibetan translation.²⁴ This section, composed in verse, recounts the journey of the Buddha and his predictions about the construction of stupas. Verse 15 states: “Seeing this, Indra appeared and the Buddha told him that in the future King Milinda would also build a stupa.”²⁵

24. Vaidya, first ed. and Tripathi, second ed. 1959, 6; Demiéville 1924, 37–39.

25. Trans. in Black 1997, 57; in Sanskrit: *tatra saṃdarsanāyātām bhagavānindram abravīt | milindro nāma rājāsmin deśe stūpaṃ kariṣyati || 15 ||*

The Milinda here is referring to the interlocutor depicted in the Milinda-Nāgasena dialogue. It appears that even in the eleventh century, the memory of King Milinda survived in North West India.

It has been reported that Nāgasena was a well-known figure in Tibetan literature (Waddell 1897, 229; Jampalyang 2019, 1129). However, Tibetan tradition considers Nāgasena to be a contemporary of King Nanda of Magadha around the first half of the fourth century BCE, and one of the sixteen great Elders (*Sthaviras*). The name “Nāgasena” could however be a common name, and the Nāgasena cited by these texts is perhaps not related to the Milinda-Nāgasena tradition. The name “Nāgasena” has also been found in several inscriptions in Central India, in today’s Madhya Pradesh, some dated prior to King Menander I, either with reference to monk or lay person. There is even a female donor from Pāṭaliputra named Nāgasenā (Skilling 2015 [2011], 160–162; email, 30 June 2020).

In Southeast Asia

Citations in early Burma

The first archaeological evidence that may be related to the *Milindapañha* in Burma is a votive tablet found at a site in Tadagale, located eight kilometres north of Rangoon. The reverse side of the tablet has a fragmentary Pāli inscription in tenth century writing that refers to the name “Nāgasena” (Luce 1985, 163–164). The next archaeological record, also a votive tablet, comes from Pagan in the reign of Kyanzittha (r. 1084–1113) and is dated c. 1113 (Luce 1970, 41).²⁶ The tablet depicts the Buddha seated with legs suspended, while the *verso* has nine lines of Pāli incised in Mon script with reference to Nāgasena due to his wisdom (*pañ[ñ]āya adhirocātī*). Luce interprets the inscription in a slightly different way:

[This] therā, like Nāgasena, takes keen delight in learning. By [this] work [in making] a thousand Buddhas, [may he become] a Buddha in [his] future existence. The work was done by the monk named Sumedha, with his own hand, for the sake of Deliverance.²⁷

Sumedha here refers to one of seven monks associated with Rājakumāra, the son of King Kyanzittha, and who stamped the thousand votive tablets of “Chitsagōn.” Luce considered the Nāgasena in this inscription to be the Nāgasena of the *Milindapañha* (Luce 1969, 76).

The first mention of a manuscript of the *Milindapañha* in Southeast Asia is found in a thirteenth century inscription. In this Pagan inscription, dated 1223, a “*Milindapañhā*” is listed among a group of works (manuscripts) donated to a monastic library (Than Tun 1998, 38–41). Later, another manuscript, the *Milinda paññā*, is part of a large donation of a “Tripiṭaka Library” made to a temple in Pagan in 1442. Here, the *Milinda paññā* is item 251 out of 299 manuscripts (Luce and Htway 1976, 203–256). These inscriptions show that the *Milindapañha* must have already been

26. Kyanzittha is Aniruddha’s general, who succeeded Saw Lu as king; see Luce 1969, 50.

27. || therō yathā nāgaseno pañāya adhirocātī sahaṣṣa || buddha kammēna buddho tassa anāgate || sumedho nāma bhikkhunā kato || vimuttatthaṃ sahatthenevātī. Translation adapted from Luce 1970, 42.

circulating in Burma in the tenth century, if not earlier, making it familiar enough for Nāgasena to be cited as an ideal in the early twelfth century. However, no firmly dated Pagan-era manuscript has ever been found.

One of the earliest known Pāli *Milindapañha* manuscripts extant in Burma was copied in 1758.²⁸ Formerly, it was preserved at the Bagaya Monastery, just south of Mandalay, but it is now kept at the National Library of Myanmar in Nay Pyi Taw.²⁹ Another Burmese manuscript (date unavailable) is stored at the British Library in London.³⁰ The other surviving manuscripts mostly date to the eighteenth or nineteenth centuries CE (Lammerts 2010, 233 and 238).³¹

Citations in Sukhothai

As for Siam,³² in the *Treatise of the Three Worlds* (*Traibhūmikathā*), a cosmological treatise, believed to have been composed by King Lithai of Sukhothai (r. 1347–1368) in the fourteenth century, the *Milindapañha* is mentioned as *Phra Milindapañhā* and *Phra Milinda* in the front and back colophons respectively among more than thirty other titles.³³ Early Sukhothai Buddhism may be influenced by the Ayutthaya tradition (before that Lopburi), at that time a rising new kingdom, as well as the monastic orders of Sinhalese lineages coming particularly from Rāmaññadesa (Land of the Mon, Lower Burma). In c. 1320, the monk Sumana from Sukhothai travelled to Ayutthaya in search of the *Tripitaka* (Griswold and Prasert 1972, 24; Charnvit Kasetsiri 1976, 85). Later the same monk went to Martaban in Rāmaññadesa to be trained under the prominent Sinhalese Mahāthera Udumbara Mahāsāmi (Dhammasami 2018, 92). Sumana returned to Sukhothai upon the request of the king and played an important role in developing Buddhism in the Sukhothai Kingdom under King Luthai (r. 1298–1323) (Hazra 1981, 145–146). Soon after, according to Griswold and Prasert Na Nagara, in 1361, a prominent monk of another Sinhalese lineage based in Martaban, Mahāthera Medhañkara, came to Sukhothai upon the invitation of King Lithai (Griswold and Prasert Na Nagara 1973, 94–99). The Mahāthera was the author of a cosmological text called the *Lokappadīpakasāra*, which was one of the texts that King Lithai consulted in his composition of the *Traibhūmikathā* (Pattaratorn Chirapavati 2009, 174).

28. The colophon clearly gives the year as (*Sakkarājī*) 1120 (1758 CE), but the label gives it as (*Sakkarājī*) 1020 (1658 CE).

29. For the manuscript images, see <https://mmdl.utoronto.ca/databases/national-library-of-myanmar/m-o/>. Accessed on 20 November 2020. I would like to thank Anthony Scott for highlighting this to me.

30. Shelf mark IO Man/Pali 126. It was previously kept at the Indian Office Library in Mandalay.

31. A collection of twenty-four *Milindapañha* manuscripts is listed in Peter Nyunt's two volumes *Descriptive Catalogue of Burmese Manuscripts in Fragile Palm leaves Collection* (Nyunt 2014a and 2014b). These manuscripts are dated from the eighteenth to the early twentieth centuries. The oldest among them was copied in 1771.

32. Siam here is defined as the territory of Central Siam (see n.4) covering the periods of Thai history spanning from Sukhothai in the mid-thirteenth century, followed by Ayutthaya, Thonburi and up to the present Rattanakosin.

33. Reynolds and Reynolds 1982, 349–350; Royal Institute [of Thailand] (ราชบัณฑิตยสถาน) 2001, 4 and 268.

By the end of the fourteenth century, there were various groups of Sinhalese monks or their successors in the Sukhothai Kingdom. They can either be traced directly to Sinhalese fraternities in Ceylon or to orders based in Martaban. Sukhothai's access to the *Milindapañha* probably took place around this period. Unfortunately, there is currently no evidence to suggest that any of the surviving *Milindapañha* manuscripts or its Thai translation is a descendant of the Sukhothai tradition.³⁴

The oldest Milindapañha manuscript (L^{LH}) and Lan Na

The oldest surviving *Milindapañha* manuscript is found at Wat Lai Hin in Lampang, Northern Thailand (L^{LH}).³⁵ It was copied in 1495. However, it is not complete. Its colophon states: “Sakarāja 857, in the year *dap hmau* (Year of the Hare), the *Milindapañha* has been donated by Nāy Sin Prahyā to the Dā Soy Library” (von Hinüber 1987, 111). Dā Soy was a town located at the south of Lamphun, southwest of Lampang or 22 km to the northwest of the present day Bhumibol Dam (Hundius 1990, 8 [map] and 67). Dā Soy was once a prosperous township with important monasteries where many important Pāli manuscripts were made as donations. At present, the town Dā Soy lies under water due to the construction of the dam (Hundius 1990, 36, 67). At one point in its history, L^{LH} was brought to Wat Lai Hin and has been kept there since. L^{LH} was well copied in Tham Lan Na script. Based on a possible misreading of letters in Sinhalese script during the transliteration to Lan Na script, von Hinüber is of the opinion that the ultimate origin of L^{LH} seems to be Ceylon (von Hinüber 1987, 116). It seems possible, as the area was known to have been under the strong influence of the Sinhalese Buddhist tradition.

The regions of Dā Soy and Lampang were, at the time, part of Lan Na Kingdom (Kingdom of a Million Rice Fields) in Northern Thailand. The fifteenth and sixteenth centuries CE are widely regarded as the “golden age” of Pāli scholarship in Lan Na, when Buddhism enjoyed strong royal patronage. Lan Na was a major centre of Buddhist learning in Southeast Asia (Grabowsky 2007, 122). It was also in this period that two other texts related to the *Milindapañha* were purportedly compiled in this Northern Kingdom. One is a commentary on the *Milindapañha*, the *Milinda-ṭīkā*, believed to have been composed in Bingaraṭṭha (Chiang Mai) around the year 1474 (Mil-ṭ xiii–xiv). The other is the *Milindapañhagāthā*, a composition entirely in verse embedded in a larger text, the *Vaṃsamālinī* (see below). According to the *Chronicle of the Emerald Buddha* (*Ratanabimbavaṃsa*), which was also composed in Lan Na in the fifteenth century CE, the palladium of the Kingdom of Thailand, the Emerald Buddha, was created in ancient India at the instigation of Nāgasena before it was brought to Thailand (Chiu 2017, 20–21; Pariyatidhammadhātā 1912/1913, 110). These compositions show an awareness and reception of the *Milindapañha*

34. Skilling 2010, 22 and n.13.

35. For more information on this manuscript, see von Hinüber 1987, 111–119; von Hinüber 1988, 173–174; von Hinüber 2013, 112–113; Hundius 1990, 63–64; The images of this manuscript can be viewed at the Digital Library of Northern Thai Manuscripts, code PNTMP 030102024_00 at www.lannamanuscripts.net.

in Lan Na at that time. Nāgasena seems to be a well-known sage in Lan Na, and to some extent he was popular in Central Siam and in Cambodia too. In Khom manuscript colophons, as well as in Khmer inscriptions, we find people who express the aspiration to be as wise as him in future lives.³⁶

Unfortunately, very few manuscripts copied during these periods have survived. They may have succumbed to the ravages of time or been the victims of elongated wars fought over the centuries.

The manuscript of Champassak, Laos

A second *Milindapañha* manuscript, copied in 1637 and is now kept at Vat Nyuttithammathalam in Champassak, Southern Laos.³⁷ The manuscript was most likely copied during the reign of King Suriyavongsa (r. 1633/38–1690/95) of the Kingdom of Lan Sang (Kingdom of a Million Elephants).³⁸ I assume this manuscript was brought to Southern Laos most probably from Luang Prabang or perhaps from Vientiane, as Vat Nyuttithammathalam was built much later in the reign of Cau Kham Suk (r. 1863–1900) (Grabowsky 2007, 136), who then ruled the Kingdom of Champassak.³⁹ The colophon at the last folio reads:

Sakarāja 999 [1637 CE], a *mueang pao* year [Year of the Ox, Ninth of the Decade]. [As for this manuscript of the] *Milindapañhā*, Chao Lu, together with [his] wife, sponsored it out of faith. Somdet Saṅgharājā Manoabhirammā Chao was the interior supporter.

The textual tradition of this manuscript is quite similar to the one kept at Wat Lai Hin. A cursory analysis does not show any direct filiation between the two, but they may have descended from an intermediate textual tradition.⁴⁰

Theravaṃsa Buddhism in Lan Sang Kingdom flourished between the reigns of King Vangbuli (r. 1441/2–1487) and King Setthathirat (r. 1548–1571) (Lorrillard 2006, 141–143). During that period, Lan Sang established close political and religious ties with its neighbour Lan Na, which at that time was a major centre of Buddhist learning (Grabowsky 2007, 122). The interaction between these two kingdoms might have resulted in exchanges of many Buddhist texts. For example, it is recorded in the *Jinakālamālī*, a sixteenth century CE chronicle from Northern Thailand, that in 1523, the King of Lan Na (King Mūang Kaeo) offered King Phothisararat (r. 1520–1548) of Lan Sang sixty volumes of the Pāli canon and other gifts (Jayawickrama 1978, 183; Lorrillard 2006, 143). It is possible, therefore, that as part of such exchanges,

36. For examples of colophons that cite Nāgasena as an ideal, see Appendix III in Ooi 2021, 206.

37. The images of the manuscript can be viewed at the Digital Library of Lao Manuscripts, www.laomanuscripts.net PLMP code 16070204006_00.

38. The Kingdom of Lan Sang refers to the trans-Mekong River kingdoms that evolved into present day Laos.

39. The Kingdom of Lan Sang broke up into three kingdoms after the death of King Suriyavongsa, namely the Kingdoms of Luang Prabang, Vientiane and Champassak: see Grabowsky 2007, 135.

40. The term “filiation” or “filiated,” determined through shared errors, is used to ascertain whether two manuscripts are more closely related than others in a group of manuscripts with similar textual tradition. For further discussion of this term, see Adluri and Bagchee 2018, 164.

the *Milindapañha* was transmitted via Lan Na to Lan Sang between the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries CE.

Citations in Cambodia

The earliest indication of possible influence of the text in Cambodia is through the post-Angkorian Khmer *Grande Inscription d'Angkor* or IMA 32, dated 1687, which has a prose passage (Lewitz 1973, 228):

Transliterated Khmer	English Translation ^a
<i>sūm khñuṃm mān prājñā thlā thlai</i> (42) <i>vaṃy moḥhimā tūc braḥ mahānā</i> (43) <i>ggasen hoñ</i>	May I be endowed with radiant intelligence, fast and fierce, just like Braḥ Mahānāggasen (Nāgasena).

The aspiration to be as intelligent as Nāgasena also appears in IMA 38, dated 1701 CE, which states, at verse 116 (Pou-Lewitz 1975, 304):

Transliterated Khmer	English Translation ^b
<i>khñuṃ sūm prājñā coeḥ chloey prisnā</i> <i>toḥ srāy sār šaṇ tūc braḥ nāggasen</i> <i>chloey prisnā phoñ. nū kruṇ mālin hoñ</i> <i>toḥ it jumḃāk</i>	I humbly ask for intelligence, the skill to respond to riddles and resolve them in debate, just like Nāgasena who answered all the riddles before King Mālin (Milinda), resolving them without a hitch.

a. I would like to thank Trent Walker for highlighting this to me as well as providing the English translations: email 9 July 2020.

b. Trans. Trent Walker: email 9 July 2020.

The presence of a *Milindapañha* manuscript in Cambodia is attested by the Vatt Tā Tok inscription (K. 892), a small square/cubic sandstone stele discovered in Siem Reap, dated to 1857. At Face III of the stele, lines no. 11 and 12 state *kruṇ mālin nākasen khse 6*, translated as “King Milinda and Nāgasena in six bundles,” as one of the manuscripts donated by a monk named Hmin to the temple (de Bernon 2012, 377–378).

There are also a number of *Milindapañha* manuscripts in the Khmer language found in various temples. Most of them are undated and some are dated to the twentieth century.⁴¹ The texts in Khmer language were most probably adopted from a Thai version which itself is based on the Pāli version (Jacob 1996, 49). From the IMA 32 inscription, where people aspired to be as wise as Nāgasena, it can be adduced this interlocutor in the *Milindapañha* was already known in the local community before the inscription was made. Thus, the *Milindapañha* text was likely transmitted to Cambodia earlier than the surviving records show.

41. For a provisional inventory of manuscripts in Cambodia, see Oliver de Bernon, Kun Sopheap & Leng Kok-An 2004.

Transmission of the Siamese *Milindapañha*

Manuscripts of the Ayutthaya period

The period of the history of Ayutthaya (1351–1767) generally covers the area of Central Siam. The script used in this region is called the Khom script, a cognate of Khmer script. It has been the main script for recording Pāli texts in Central Siam (including Sukhothai) from the fourteenth century to the late nineteenth or early twentieth century during both the Ayutthaya and Rattanakosin Periods (1782–present).⁴² Therefore, if a manuscript is written in Khom script, it is commonly regarded as having circulated in Central Siam. However, this does not mean that its transmission is limited to this region only. The other script that is common in Central Siam is the Mon script. Mon Buddhist traditions can be traced back to the time of *Dvāravatī* in the sixth or seventh century CE. However, the Mon of Central Siam today are mostly descendants of Mon groups, who migrated between the sixteenth and early nineteenth centuries in stages, from Rāmaññadesa, crossing the Tenasserim Hills to settle in the Chao Phraya basin (Van Roy 2010, 151).

History has it that the Burmese-Ayutthaya war ended in 1767 with the sacking and burning of Ayutthaya capital after which the city lay abandoned. This resulted in the loss of many important documents including Buddhist manuscripts (Charnvit Kasetsiri 1976, 52). Only a handful of Pāli *Milindapañha* manuscripts copied in the Ayutthaya period survive today. Most of them are kept at the National Library of Thailand. Two are preserved in the Bibliothèque nationale de France in Paris and Trinity College Library in Cambridge respectively, and another one was found at Wat Samuh Nimit, located at Chaiya District, Surat Thani Province in Southern Thailand.⁴³ However, they are not complete. These manuscripts are dated between the second half of the seventeenth century and the first half of the eighteenth century. Amongst them are two recensions which differ significantly in terms of their respective textual traditions. I name one of them *Chabap Ayutthaya* (CA), or the Ayutthaya recension, in view of the location and period in which witnesses to it were copied, and the other *Chabap Lamphun* (CL), or the Lamphun recension, because it was categorized as such in some manuscripts. They have not so far been studied, at least not via utilization of modern methodology.

Lamphun recension (CL)

Certain manuscripts kept at the National Library come with a title folio stating “*Brah̐ Milindapañhā Chabap Lāmbhūñ*” sometimes the “*chabap*” (recension) is spelt as “*japap*”⁴⁴ perhaps following the oral pronunciation. The word *Lāmbhūñ* most likely refers to the old city of Lamphun in Northern Thailand, which has a history that goes back to the legendary Queen Cāmadevī, who came from Lopburi and founded

42. Skilling and Santi Pakdeekham 2002, 5 and n.2.

43. The Trinity College manuscript images are not available for examination at the time of writing this article. For further information of this manuscript, see Aufrecht 1869, 85–86 (Code: R.15.150). I would like to thank Nicolas Bell for highlighting this to me.

44. NL4583 *phūk* 11 has it as *chapap*.

the Haripuñjaya Kingdom in the North with Lamphun as its capital (Coedès 1975, 77) in the seventh century CE (Swearer and Premchit 1998, 164). Haripuñjaya was ruled by Mon kings until 1292, when it was overpowered and became part of the Lan Na Kingdom (Coedès 1975, 208).

There is little information as to why they are called the Lamphun recension. The most logical reason is due to their transmission history, these manuscripts being descendants of a common manuscript found in Lamphun or its surrounding region. The National Library manuscripts that contain the label “*Chabap Lāmbhūñ*” (CL) are NL4578, NL4583,⁴⁵ NL5107 and NL6133.⁴⁶ Out of these four manuscripts, the last three come from a similar textual tradition. They are single and isolated *phūk* or palm-leaf fascicles.⁴⁷ However, NL4578, is a mixed bundle. *Phūk* 1, the only *phūk* with the label CL, has a textual tradition similar to the earlier three manuscripts. But, from *phūk* 2 onwards, the text is in accord with CA.⁴⁸ Based on these loose *phūk* found in the Library, I am quite hesitant to label those manuscripts as CL. Nevertheless, we get a better picture when turning to another manuscript found at Wat Samuh Nimit (SN1).

This SN1 manuscript comes in thirteen *phūk* with the first and second *phūk* missing. It is undated but after a palaeographic assessment, I think it was copied in the Ayutthaya period. One distinctive feature about this manuscript is that at every title folio of each *phūk* (except *phūk* 4 and 6), we find the label “*Milindapañhā Japap Lāmbhūñ*” (Figure 2). The textual characteristic of this manuscript is similar to the manuscripts mentioned above. In my opinion, this recension corresponds to the *Milindapañhā Chabap Lamphun*. The textual tradition of this manuscript is somewhat in agreement with that of Mil and the *Chaṭṭhasaṅgīti* edition.

The next question is why this is called “*Chabap Lamphun*,” a name associated with Northern Thailand, when, at this moment, it is found only in Central and Southern Siam? To answer this question, let us take a look at the Lan Na-script L^{LI}. We have discussed earlier that L^{LI} was copied in Dā Soy, a town located to the south of Lamphun and southwest of Lampang. The textual tradition of L^{LI} is in accord with CL, however, this manuscript is not filiated to the manuscripts kept at the National Library or Wat Samuh Nimit, but may come from a further recension. If indeed, the hyparchetype of CL came from this Northern region, this could mean that there was more than one copy of the *Milindapañha* belonging to a similar textual tradition circulating in the Lamphun-Lampang region in Northern Thailand at one point of time, perhaps during the heyday of Lan Na Pāli scholarship. However, only one of them survived and is preserved at Wat Lai Hin today.

45. NL4583 is a mixed bundle with different sets of incomplete manuscripts. This is a single *phūk* (no. 11). Another set with two *phūk* (No. 4–5), is a CA recension (see Table 2).

46. NL6133 has four different sets of manuscripts. This is a single *phūk* (no. 1). Another set with ten *phūk* (no. 5–10, 12–15) is a CA recension (see Table 2).

47. Each *phūk* or fascicle usually contains 24 palm-leaf folios written on both sides.

48. The text in *phūk* 1 does not continue in *phūk* 2. There is some degree of overlap i.e. *phūk* 2 starts with what *phūk* 1 has already covered. Moreover the calligraphic style is different between *phūk* 1 and 2.

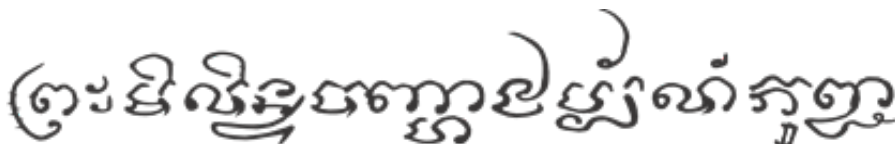


Figure 2 The title of SN1 (in Khom script), *phūk 3: braḥ milindapañhā japap lāmbhūñ*.

Another possible reason to name this group of manuscripts as CL is the need to differentiate them from another group of *Milindapañha* manuscripts which do not share the same textual tradition, that is CA.

In light of the fact that SN1 is not complete, CL can be represented through the collation of manuscripts NL5008–377–SN1 (indicated by ■ in Table 1). NL377 is a hybrid manuscript (see below) while NL5008 is a single *phūk*, independent manuscript and is the oldest dated *Milindapañha* manuscript kept at the National Library.

Table 1 Chabap Lamphun and the number of *phūk* available.

Year CE	NL no.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15
1686	5008	■														
1727	377 ^a		■	•	•	•	•	•		•	•	•	•	•	•	•
Ayutth ^b	SN1			■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■	■

a. A hybrid manuscript.

b. Samuh Nimit manuscript no. 1 (SN1) is estimated to be copied in the late Ayutthaya period.

Ayutthaya recension (CA)

Meanwhile, manuscripts of CA, for example NL6133 (dated 1755) and NL4596 (dated 1687), represent a rather different textual tradition compared to CL. The textual characteristic of CA copied in the Ayutthaya period seems to form the core textual base of another recension or *Chabap Krung Thep* (CKT or the Bangkok recension) which in turn, I believe, is one of the main manuscripts from which Si was derived (see below).

As these manuscripts are incomplete, CA can be best represented by the collation of manuscripts NL4068–5215–6133–4606 (indicated by ■ in Table 2).⁴⁹ Even though NL4068 is undated and is estimated to be copied in the Rattanakosin period, this manuscript is closely filiated to NL5215, through the assessment of shared errors and omissions.

While the textual tradition of CA manuscripts copied in the Ayutthaya period remain in agreement, they have their own way of classifying or counting the number of dialogues. For example, in NL5215, Part II–III of the text ends with

49. NL6133 is selected as the base of the collation because it has the most *phūk* extant. NL5215, a standalone *phūk*, is most likely part of NL6133, which is placed in another entry. The textual tradition of NL5215–6133 is closely filiated with the older NL4596 and NL4583. Nevertheless, both NL4583 and NL4596 are consulted in the analysis.

Table 2 *Chabap Ayutthaya* and the number of *phūk* available.

Year CE	NL no.	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14	15	16
1687	4596					•		•	•				•	•	•	•	
1688	4583				•	•											
1747	BnF ^a				•	•											
1755	4606						•		•	•		■		•	•	•	
1755	5215				■												
1755	6133					■	■	■	■	■	■		■	■	■	■	
Rattana ^b	4068	■	■	■	•	•	•	•	•	•	•	•	•	•	•	•	•

a. Preserved in Bibliothèque nationale de France (BnF), code: Pali 362. This manuscript is closely filiated with NL5215. <https://archivesetmanuscrits.bnf.fr/ark:/12148/cc98556h>. Accessed on 26 August 2021.

b. NL4068 is estimated to be copied in the Rattanakosin period.

aṭṭhāsītipaṇhāni tāmbapaṇṇadīpapasādakāni samattāni or “these eighty-eight questions [of this recension of the *Milindapañha* transmitted by those] which brought clarity/the faith to the Isle of Tambapaṇṇa are completed.”⁵⁰ While NL4853 ends with *ekanavuttipaṇhapaṭimaṇḍito milindapaṇho niṭṭhito* or “in this way [the part] on *Milindapañha*, adorned with ninety-one questions, is completed.” The difference in numbers is confusing, therefore a better way to count the questions or dialogues is by calibrating as shown in Table 3.

Table 3 illustrates the number of dialogues found in each recension calibrated to Si, meaning that if another recension counted the passage as two dialogues, but Si combined the two and counts it as one, the table will show one each for both recensions and vice versa. From Table 3, we can see that the framework of CA differs from other Siamese recensions (CL and CKT) and other printed editions.⁵¹ Discrepancies are due to the absence of some dialogues in certain recensions as well as the presence of cognate dialogues.

Cognate dialogues look like duplicates and are found in the same recension. The presence of cognate dialogue is intriguing. This is very much due to intertextual influences during a redaction process, for example, CKT could be the result of CA selected readings from CL or other sources. We shall examine some of them in further detail shortly (see below).

The framework of the *Milindapañha* is roughly divided into six parts, as outlined in Table 3. These parts are also expressed in the beginning of the text (Mil 2; Si 4), with the exception of the *paṇāmagāthā* (*Verses of Homage*). Nonetheless, these recen-

50. The compound, “place” + “*pasādikā*,” seems to mean “brought clarity” or “brought faith” to that place (Skilling 1993, 168 and n.3; Cousins 2001, 141). Similar constructions to this compound in colophons are also found in two third century Prakrit inscriptions in Nāgārjunakoṇḍa, in the Āndhradeśa region of South India (*Epigraphia Indica* [EI], Vol. XX, 1929–30, 22–23; *Epigraphia Indica* [EI], Vol. XXXIII, 1959–60, 247–250; Tournier 2018, 51–52 and 55), and in Vin II 72.27–29.

51. Cf. the *Vessantara Jātaka*, where there are dissimilarities in the number of verses in different recensions: see Cicuzza and Skilling 2010, 35–45.

Table 3 The number of questions or dialogues in different editions/recensions.^a

Parts ^b	Names	Si	Mil/ Horner	CST4	Chinese NBS	CKT	CA	CL
I	<i>Paṇāmagāthā</i>	X	—	—	—	X	—	X
	<i>Pubbayoga</i>	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
II–III	<i>Milindapañha</i>	88	84	84	78	88	86	84
IV–a	<i>Meṇḍakapañha</i>	87 ^c	83	51		89 ^c	82 ^c	83
V	<i>Anumānapañha</i>	(1) ^d	1	34		1	1	1
IV–b	<i>Yogikathāpañha</i> or <i>Dhutaṅgapañha</i>	(1) ^d	1	(1) ^e	NA	1	1	1
VI	<i>Opammakathāpañha</i>	67	67	67		67	66	67

a. The number of questions/dialogues is calibrated to Si; NBS = T1670B; CKT = NL333; CA = NL4068–5215–6133–4606; CL = 5008–377–SN1; CST4 = *Chaṭṭha Saṅgāyana Tipiṭaka* version 4; Horner trans. 1963, v, vi and 34–124; Horner trans. 1969, v–iv; NA = Not Applicable.

b. The six parts are as expressed in the text.

c. Including the *gotamīvattadānapañha*.

d. Counted in Part IV–a. In Si, the *Anumānapañha* and the *Yogikathāpañha* are counted as parts of the *Meṇḍakapañha* in a total of nine divisions.

e. Counted in Part V.

sions may differ in how each section is named. For example, certain recensions have included the part on *Anumānapañha* in the *Meṇḍakapañha* instead of separately. On the other hand, some do not consider *Yogikathāpañha* as part of the *Meṇḍakapañha*.

Part I: The *paṇāmagāthā* and *pubbayoga*

Part I consists of two parts in Si: The *paṇāmagāthā* (Si 1–3) and the *pubbayoga* or the past connection between King Milinda and Nāgasena. The *paṇāmagāthā* is placed at the beginning of the text and is entirely absent from other Pāli printed editions and the Chinese NBS. It consists of approximately 350 Pāli words and is in two parts. The first part has five verses paying obeisance to the three jewels. The second part narrates parts of the Buddha’s address to his monks at the time of his demise (*parinibbāna*) in Kusinārā. Here, the Buddha reiterates what he had declared to them so far, as well as predicting the three recital councils and the debate between King Milinda and Nāgasena five hundred years after his passing.⁵² The *paṇāmagāthā* is also found in the opening of another related Pāli text, the *Milindapañha Saṅkhepa*, an “abridged” version of the *Milindapañha*.⁵³

I think the *paṇāmagāthā* is a later addition to the Siamese recensions, taken either from the *Saṅkhepa* version or another text. I have observed the “assimilation” process through a set of closely filiated manuscripts: NL11815 (dated 1782) does not have the *paṇāmagāthā*, then NL4600 (undated) has two additional palm-leaf folios, with the *paṇāmagāthā*, placed on top of its first *phūk*, and lastly NL5435 (dated 1793)

52. For an English translation of the *paṇāmagāthā*, see Skilling 2010, 5–11.

53. For example, in NL45 and NL3658, *Bra Milindapañhā Saṅkhepa*.

has “assimilated” the *paṇāmagāthā* as part of the text, which flows seamlessly. The CA manuscripts copied in the Ayutthaya era, which I have access to, do not have the *paṇāmagāthā*. But the *paṇāmagāthā* are found in their filiated manuscripts like NL4600 and NL5435 copied later in the Rattanakosin period. At this moment, the earliest dated *Milindapañha* that comes with the *paṇāmagāthā* is NL5008 of CL recension, copied in 1686. Therefore, the process of assimilation started in the Ayutthaya period and persisted through the Rattanakosin era, and continues still in the printed edition (Si) in the early twentieth century.

The difference in details in the *Pubbayoga* will not be discussed here. However, I would like to highlight one point. According to the *Pubbayoga*, when Nāgasena went to Asokārāma in Pāṭaliputra to learn the *Tripiṭaka* from Dhammarakkhita, a monk named Tissadatta was present at the scene. Tissadatta is said to have mastered all the *buddhavaṇṇa* (the word of the Buddha), presumably all that was available on the island of Tambapaṇṇa, before travelling to Pāṭaliputra to study under Dhammarakkhita.⁵⁴ Initially, Nāgasena refused to learn with Tissadatta. He called him a Sinhalese (*sihaḷaka*), an unknown (*aviññāta*) foreign figure (*milakkha*). But he later relented after two rounds of persuasion from Dhammarakkhita (Si 25–26; CA: NL4068, khai-v.2). The presence of Tissadatta is intriguing; he is absent in CL and Mil. At the moment, it is unclear as to whether the presence of Tissadatta will shed light on the transmission history of the CA recension.

Part II–III: The *Milindapañha*

Table 4 lists the dialogues that made up the gaps among the three Siamese recensions, NBS, Mil/CTS4 and Si. The ten dialogues listed in the table are not found in NBS. From Table 4, it can be seen that the difference between Mil and NBS are six dialogues instead of seven as calculated by Guan Xing (Guan Xing 2008b, 236–237). I have taken the short dialogue on “Seeing the Dharma” (*dharmaditṭhapañha*)—which is otherwise said to be absent in the Chinese version, to be found in the last part of the preceding dialogue, with King Milinda asking Nāgasena “自見佛經道” (T1670B [32] 716b28)—as “have you seen the Dharma yourself.”

It is noteworthy that Mil, edited by Trenckner in 1880 CE, relies primarily upon four Sinhalese manuscripts which he labelled B, A, C, and D, and on a Burmese manuscript, M. However, he refers to M only sparingly. As such, the textual characteristic of Trenckner’s Mil somewhat reflects the textual tradition of Ceylon. Si does not record its sources, giving no reference whatsoever to the manuscript(s) upon which it is based. We assume that the manuscript(s) belongs to the National Library collection.

In Part II–III, CA has two additional dialogues compared to CL: In Table 4, No. 5, “Question on the Distinguishing Mark of Consideration” (*manasikāralakkhaṇapañha*)⁵⁵ and No. 10, “Question on Discerning Wisdom” (*paññāvisesapañha*).⁵⁶ The lat-

54. Tissadatta is also mentioned in the Vibh-a, as one who had mastered eighteen languages and then travelled to learn from a Greek Elder, Dhammarakkhita (Vibh-a 387–389).

55. Corresponding to Si 87.

56. Corresponding to Si 125.

Table 4 Discrepancies of dialogues among recensions in Part II–III

No.	Names of dialogues as per Si	Si	Mil/ CST4	CKT	CA	CL	NBS
Part II–III:							
1	Question on Seniority (<i>vassapañha</i>)	X	X	X	X	X	—
2	Question on the Distinguishing Mark of Consideration (<i>manasikāralakkhaṇapañha</i>) ^a	X	X	X	X	X	—
3	Question on the Distinguishing Mark of Consciousness (<i>viññāṇalakkhaṇapañha</i>)	X	X	X	X	X	—
4	Question on the Distinguishing Mark of Reflection (<i>vitakalakkhaṇapañha</i>)	X	X	X	X	X	—
5	Question on the Distinguishing Mark of Consideration (<i>manasikāralakkhaṇapañha</i>)	X	—	X	X	—	—
6	Question on Establishing Wisdom (<i>paññāya patitṭhānapañha</i>) ^b	X	X	X	X	X	—
7	Question on the Cycle of Rebirth (<i>saṃsārapañha</i>)	X	X	X	X	X	—
8	Question on One who has Gone to the World Beyond: whether he goes in a Form that is Blue, Yellow or Another [Colour] (<i>paralokagatanīlapitādivaṇṇagatapañha</i>)	X	—	X	—	—	—
9	Question on Connection to the Mother's Womb [in a New Existence] (<i>mātukucchipaṭisandhipañha</i>)	X	—	X	—	—	—
10	Question on Discerning Wisdom (<i>paññāvisesapañha</i>)	X	—	X	X	—	—

a. No. 2 and 5, despite having the same dialogue names, differ in content, i.e. No. 2 has another question: “what is wisdom?”

b. No. 6 and 10 both are cognate dialogues.

ter is a cognate dialogue to No. 6, “Question on Establishing Wisdom” (*paññāya patitṭhānapañha*).

In general, for the Part, despite the differences in their textual traditions, CA and CL are pretty much in agreement in terms of framework and sequence of dialogues.

Part IV: The *Meṇḍakapañha*

In Part IV, the *Meṇḍakapañha* or the section on the *Dilemmas*, the situation is more complex. Both the sequences of topics and details in the questions and answers differ significantly between these two recensions.

First, CA, through the NL6133 group of manuscripts, is missing two dialogues: 1) “Question on the Arising of the Path which has not Arisen” (*anuppannassa maggassa uppādapañha*) (Si 293–297; Mil 217–219) and the “Question on the Blessed One as a King” (*bhagavato rājapāñha*) (Si 308–312; Mil 225–227) which are found in other Pāli recensions (No. 7 and 8 in Table 5). The former is a dilemma about whether the Buddha himself outlines a path which has not arisen, or he gets the idea through seeing the practice of past Buddhas. The latter is the dilemma of how one can be two castes in one birth, relating to separate incidents where the Buddha declared himself a Brahmin (*brāhmaṇa*) and a king (*khattiya*). It is unclear, at this moment, as to why these two are absent in CA. This could be a characteristic of a sub-group of CA recension.

Table 5 also shows the presence of cognate dialogues in the Siamese recensions. They are presented in two ways:

1. Two cognates are found respectively in either CA or CL, but both are found in CKT. The four pairs listed are:
 - a. No. 1 and 9
 - b. No. 2 and 5
 - c. No. 3 and 6
 - d. No. 4 and 12
2. Two cognate dialogues are found only in a specific recension:

In CKT:

 - a. No. 10 and a cognate of the same name: “Question on Defects in the Path” (*paṭipadādosapāñha*).⁵⁷
 - b. No. 11 and “Question on a Householder as an Arahant” (*gihi-arahattapāñha*).

In CA:

 - a. No. 13 and “Question on the Giving of Cloths by Gotamī” (*gotamīvattadānapāñha*).

Overall, Si has two pairs of cognate dialogues in Part IV, while CKT has six pairs and CA has one.

Part IV, through NL6133 (CA), ends with the sub-colophon: *iti meṇḍakapañho ubhato koṭiko pañho pañcasattatipañhehi paṭimaṇḍito niṭṭhito* or “In this way, the [section on] double-pronged Meṇḍaka questions (dilemmas), consisting of seventy-five questions is completed.” The seventy-five dialogues are divided into seven divisions (*vagga*) with ten dialogues each except the last division that comes in fifteen. It does not include the part on “Questions on Ascetic Practices” (*yogikathāpāñha*) which in turn is called “the Question[s] on [Ascetic] Qualities” (*lakkhaṇapāñha*).

Part V: The *Anumānapañha*

As for Part V, the *Anumānapañha* (“Questions [Solved by] Inference”), in CA this is divided into ten subdivisions. Each subdivision has a specific inference (see Table 6) and ends with, for example, *tatiyānumānapañho niṭṭhito* (“Question [solved by] the Third Inference is completed”). CA and CKT come with detailed explanatory text

57. Not listed in Table 5, as it is found in all Pāli recensions discussed here.

Table 5 Discrepancies of dialogues among recensions in Part IV.

No.	Names of dialogues as per Si	Si	Mil/ CST4	CKT	CA	CL	NBS
Part IV:							
1	Question on Praising a Householder and a Monk who have Entered the Path (<i>gīhipabbajitapaṭipannavaṇṇanapaṇha</i>) ^a	—	—	x	x	—	NA
2	Question on being Houseless and Independent (<i>aniketānālayakaraṇapaṇha</i>)	x	—	x	x	—	
3	Question on the [Superiority of] One who is Devoted to Begging (<i>yācayogapaṇha</i>)	x	—	x	x	—	
4	Question on the Bodhisattva's Nature (<i>bodhisattassa dhammatāpaṇha</i>)	x	x	x	—	x	
5	Question on Social Interaction [of a Sage] (<i>santhavapaṇha</i>)	x	x	x	—	x	
6	Question on a Few Illnesses of the Blessed One (<i>bhagavato appābādhapaṇha</i>)	x	x	x	—	x	
7	Question on the Arising of the Path which has not Arisen (<i>anuppannassa maggassa uppādapāṇha</i>)	x	x	x	—	x	
8	Question on the Blessed One as a King (<i>bhagavato rājapaṇha</i>)	x	x	x	—	x	
9	Question on the Right Practice of a Householder and a Monk (<i>gīhipabbajitas ammāpaṭipattipaṇha</i>)	x	x	x	—	x	
10	Question on Defects in the Path (<i>paṭipadādosapaṇha</i>)	—	—	x	—	—	
11	Question on the Significance of Going Forth to a Householder in whom All Cankers are Destroyed (<i>gīhipabbajjitānaṃ khīṇāsavapabhāvaapaṇha</i>)	—	—	x	—	—	
12	Question on the Manner of Recitation of the Dharma (<i>dhammasaṅgītipariyāyapaṇha</i>)	—	—	x	x	—	
13	Question on the Cloth for the Rainy Season (<i>vassikasāṭṭakapaṇha</i>)	—	—	—	x	—	

a. Dialogue titles No. 1, 10, 11 and 12 are given in NL333 (CKT).

for each inference. However, CL, Mil and the *Chaṭṭhasaṅgīti* edition only have the explanatory text for the first two.

Part V begins with the king asking Nāgasena whether he has ever seen a Buddha. Nāgasena answers that he has not, and then states an inference—when people see a Worthy One (*arahant*), they know it is due to the teachings of the Buddha, hence they infer the existence of the Buddha from that. This is then followed by other inferences starting with an elaborated simile of the City of Dharma (*dhammanagara*) with its characteristics, types of inhabitants and the various kinds of shops within it.

In CL and Mil, the City of Dharma simile ends with a series of verses that precede the final two short paragraphs. The first part of these verses indicates that when people see the City of Dharma, by inference they know the Blessed One existed. The verses then continue with other inferences: from those concerning the Waves of Dharma (*dhammummi*), down to the Scent of Moral Habits (Table 6) but without further elaboration. In contrast, the other inferences in CA, like the Waves of Dharma and so on, are accompanied by detailed explanations before their respective verses.⁵⁸

For example, the explanatory text on the Waves of Dharma starts with the description of the great ocean and various kinds of fish living in it.⁵⁹ The ocean is then taken as a metaphor of the world. The text further provides a list of animals, birds, types of individuals that are submerged, bounded and circulating in the world-ocean. However, with the arising of the Buddha, many were set free, liberated by the Waves of Dharma. Three locations are given in the text where the Buddha expounded the Truths of the Noble Ones: concerning Suffering; its Arising; and its Cessation respectively. The three places are: the heaven of Thirty-Three Gods,⁶⁰ the Pāsāṇaka Shrine,⁶¹ and the spot where the Buddha descended from the heaven of Thirty-Three Gods.⁶² In these places, specific numbers of myriads of beings are said to have insight into the Dharma arisen in them (*dhammacakkhum udapādi*). The events of these three locations have been mentioned in other texts,⁶³ but here the text does specifically point out that the respective Truths of the Noble Ones were

58. In CA NL6133, verses are not found after the explanatory text of the City of Dharma, the Footprint of an Elephant King and the Garland of Flowers.

59. The list of fish is given in a long compound, many of which are yet to be identified.

60. *Tāvātimsabhavana*. For other teachings taught in this heaven by the Buddha, see Skilling 2008, 37–60.

61. *Pāsāṇakacetiya*. At Rājagaha. Cf. Si 453; Mil 349; Horner trans. 1969, 203 and n.14; DPPN II, 196; The disciples of Bāvari questioning the Buddha as recorded at the *pārāyanavagga* of the *Suttanipāta* (Sn v. 1013 at 194 and v. 1025 at 196). Here, besides what is recorded in the *pārāyanavagga*, also included is the teaching on the Second Truth of the Noble Ones (Arising) at the shrine.

62. This occasion is also mentioned in Si 453; Mil 350; Horner trans. 1969, 204 and n.1, which state that the Buddha descended to the City of Sankassa (DPPN II: 973) and the miracle of unveiling of the worlds (a clear view of the nine Brahma-worlds above and of Avici below) took place. On that occasion, the Buddha also preached the Dharma and the same number of people “drank the water of deathlessness” (*amatapānaṃ piviṃsu*) (Ja IV 267.6). In this passage, it specifically states that the Buddha taught the Third Truth of the Noble Ones (Cessation).

63. See notes 60, 61 and 62 above.

Table 6 The discrepancies in the *Anumānapañha* and the *Opammakathāpañha*.

Part V: Subdivisions of the <i>Anumānapañha</i>								
No	Inferences	Topics	Explanatory text					NBS
			Si	Mil/ CST4	CKT	CA	CL	
1	First	The Attainment and Teaching	x	x	x	x	x	NA
2	Second	The City of Dharma	x	x	x	x	x	
3	Third	The Waves of Dharma	x	—	x	x	—	
4	Fourth	The Mountain of Dharma	x	—	x	x	—	
5	Fifth	The Rain-cloud of Dharma	x	—	x	x	—	
6	Sixth	The Footprint of an Elephant King	x	—	x	x	—	
7	Seventh	The Roar of the King of Beasts	x	—	x	x	—	
8	Eighth	The River and the Sea of Dharma	x	—	x	x	—	
9	Ninth	The Scent of Moral Habits	x	—	x	x	—	
10	Tenth	The Garland of Flowers	x	—	x	x	—	
Part VI: The <i>Opammakathāpañha</i>								
1	<i>cāpassa ekaṅgaṃ</i>		x	x	x	—	x	NA

taught by the Buddha. The section on the Waves of Dharma then ends with the verses found in both the CA and CL recensions.

The gap between these recensions is extensive, almost sixteen written palm-leaf folios, which corresponds to seventeen pages of Si (NL6133, me-v.1-yaṃ-r.4; Si 432–449), are missing from CL and Mil. A similar situation is found in the *Opammakathāpañha* (“Questions on Talk of Similes”), where only the details of 67 similes are given in the text, when there are almost 105 listed in the tabulated summary given at the beginning.⁶⁴ The details of other similes are thought to have been lost (von Hinüber 1996, 85). As to whether CA has managed to preserve this explanatory text in the *Anumānapañha*, which CL has lost, or it is a later addition, it is difficult to ascertain at this moment.

Part VI: The *Opammakathāpañha*

Part VI, the *Opammakathāpañha* (“Questions on Talk of Similes”), which constitutes the last part of the text, concerns the kind of qualities a monk, who aspires to attain Arahantship, must adopt. In CA, the qualities are discussed in 66 similes compared to 67 in CL and other printed editions. The one missing simile is that concerning the quality of the bow (*cāpassa ekaṅgaṃ*).

Overall, the above outline gives us an idea of the structures in the Siamese recensions and how they differ from one another, as well as from other printed editions.

64. Si 467–471; Mil 363–365; Horner trans. 1969, 229 and n.1.

However, the practice of textual transmission, at least in Central Siam, is much more complex than the threefold model that we see here suggests.

Hybrid recension

Among the *Milindapañha* manuscripts found, some dated to the Ayutthaya period, is a group of manuscripts which I call the hybrid recension. A hybrid recension is a text which has a mixture of both the CA and CL textual traditions. We have seen one example earlier, NL4578. Another example is NL377, dated 1727, that comes in thirteen *phūk*. NL377 is not merely a mixture of loose *phūk* from different recensions put together in the same bundle, but there are different textual traditions visible within a single manuscript. In this manuscript, Part I–III, the textual tradition is similar to CL and it continues until the first two divisions (*vagga*) of the *Meṇḍakapañha*. From the third division onwards, the textual tradition is in agreement with CA.

The other example is NL4602, which is undated but believed to be copied in the Rattanakosin period, and is even more composite. The textual tradition starts with CA and then at the sixth division of Part II–III it switches to the textual tradition of CL, which is in agreement with SN1, including with respect to the titles of dialogues. Then at Part V, the *Anumānapañha*, the textual tradition flips back to be in agreement with CA (Figure 3).

The presence of hybrid recensions demonstrates the fluidity of textual practices in Central Siam. They could be the result of attempts to put together loose *phūk*, by compilers unaware they are from different recensions. Or it could be conscious efforts by redactors of a mingling of readings from CA and CL. Nevertheless, these texts were copied and transmitted. As such, one should be careful before assigning any *Milindapañha* manuscript to one of the three known recensions—CL, CA or CKT—as it could very well turn out to be a hybrid.

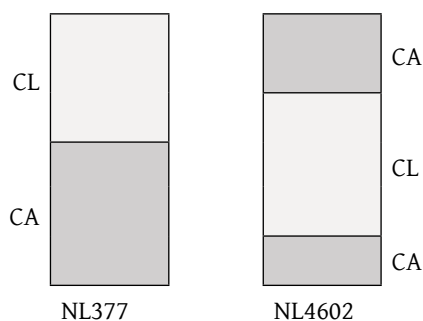


Figure 3 Hybrid recensions.

The Manuscripts of the Rattanakosin period

After the fall of Ayutthaya, Siam went through the fourteen-year Thonburi period, initiated by King Taksin (r. 1768–1782) pushing back Burmese forces. In 1782, a new Chakri dynasty came into power, which marked the beginning of the Rattanakosin era. The first king of the dynasty, King Rama I (r. 1782–1809) moved the capital to the eastern bank of the Chao Phraya river and settled in Bangkok (*Krung Thep*). Thus, the Rattanakosin era is also known as the Bangkok period.

After securing the Siamese boundaries from the Burmese, King Rama I focused his attention on the restoration of Buddhist literature. Initially, he financed a new

and complete edition of a *Tripitaka*, but soon realized that it was done in a hurry from unreliable texts (Dhani Nivat 1965, 22). In 1788, six years after he ascended the throne, a Buddhist council was convened at Wat Mahādhātu to revise and collate the Buddhist literature that could be found in the country or its neighbouring states (p. 21–30). The council met and worked for six months, which resulted in what came to be known as the *Tripitaka Chabap Thong Yai* or “The Great Gilt Edition,” written on palm-leaves and still kept at the Royal Library in the precinct of the Temple of the Emerald Buddha in the Grand Palace, Bangkok. Under the Royal Proclamation dated 1788, this council is regarded as the Ninth Buddhist Council (p. 21–30).

According to the manuscript catalogue cards, two copies of the *Milindapañha* are kept at the Royal Library. One of them (code: 101) was sponsored by Phra Phutthayotfa Chulalok Chaoyuhua (King Rama I) and Somdet Phra Bawornrajchao Maha Sura Singhanat (the Viceroy), completed in the year 1789, which is also the date of the council or very close to it.⁶⁵ This manuscript could be part of the *Chabap Thong Yai* collection.⁶⁶ As for the other manuscript (code: 98), the catalogue card does not indicate the reign in which it was copied. I do not have access to these two manuscripts. However, I assume duplicate copies of them are now preserved in the National Library.

Krung Thep recension (CKT)

The Khom-manuscript NL333, entitled “*Bra Milindapañhā*,” was copied during the reign of King Rama I and is kept under the category of “royal edition” at the National Library. I am of the opinion that it is most likely derived from the manuscript kept at the Royal Library. It comes in twenty *phūk*, compared to the fifteen to sixteen *phūk* of CA or CL. This recension is only found in the Rattanakosin period. It is most likely that around the First Reign, revisions and rearrangements were made to the *Milindapañha* which created a new recension.⁶⁷ I name it *Chabap Krung Thep* (CKT) or the Bangkok recension in view of the timing, location and era in which the revision probably took place. CKT is an open recension.⁶⁸ Its textual lineage may come from CA but it has selected some readings from CL and other sources. This is evidenced through the presence of cognate dialogues in NL333, as well as the existence of certain dialogues not found in the Ayutthaya period surviving CA and CL.

65. The Ninth Buddhist Council began in Nov 1788 and ended in April 1789, see Santi Pakadeekham 2020, xxxii–xxxiii.

66. The catalogue card does not indicate it is the *Chabap Thong Yai*. The texts that constitute the Siamese *Tripitaka* are often unclear. However, there is a unique “catalogue” in a mural painting found in the Uposatha Hall of Wat Thong Nopphakhun, Bangkok, which lists the *Milindapañha*, the *Milindapañha-tīkā* and the *Milindapañha Saṅkhepa* in the section of *Suttanta-pitaka* together with two hundred other titles; see Santi Pakadeekham 2021.

67. According to West, if rearrangement is involved in a text, it should be considered a new recension: see West 1973, 16.

68. As defined by West, a manuscript textual tradition is considered an open recension “when it does not come from a straightforward area of tradition,” and in which “worthwhile variants (other than emendations) appear for the first time, are not related perspicuously, and they do not allow us to construct an archetype”: see West 1973, 14 and 37–38.

Cognate Dialogues

Referring back to Table 4 and 5, there are seven pairs of cognate dialogues in CKT and two pairs in CA. In this article, due to the limit of space, I will only discuss two examples for the purpose of studying transmission history. The two examples are: (a) on nuns with permanent addresses and (b) on the frequency of meals the Buddha partakes in a day.

a) On nuns with permanent addresses

Cognate dialogues:

1. “A Question on being Houseless and Independent”
(*aniketānālayakaraṇapañha*) (Si 261–262)
2. “A Question on Social Interaction [of a Sage]” (*santhavapañha*) (Si 289–291; Mil 211–213)

In this pair of cognate dialogues, the king confronts Nāgasena with two statements made by the Buddha: the first, “from a ‘settled state,’ comes defilement” (therefore a monk should be houseless); and the second, “one should build pleasant dwelling-places for those who have heard much (that is, monks).” These are contradictory statements. In reply, two reasons were given by Nāgasena for the second statement. First, all Buddhas praise (*vaṇṇita*) and approve (*anumata*) the gift of a dwelling-place;⁶⁹ and second, “and again, if a residence exists, nuns who are noted for their skills (*bhikkhuniyo byattasaṅketā*) would be easy to see [for those who wish to see them]. But if they do not have a fixed place, they would be difficult see.”⁷⁰ The question now is, why do nuns appear out of the blue in this dialogue, and in what seems to be rather fallacious content.⁷¹ However, the Siamese recensions have it differently. This was first highlighted by Skilling at a workshop in Japan in 2009:⁷² “when a residence exists, many skilled monks (*bahū bhikkhū viyattā*) become accessible for those who want to see them—when they are homeless they are difficult to see.”⁷³ Here, the nuns (*bhikkhuniyo*) have disappeared and the statement makes more sense. In the CKT and Si, the section on “many skilled monks” is presented as a cognate dialogue to the “nuns with permanent addresses” (Table 7).

Von Hinüber agrees with Skilling that *bhikkhuniyo byattasaṅketā* cannot be correct.⁷⁴ He suggests that the compound could be a corruption of the original *bhikkuniyatasāṅketa* (meeting with a monk can be arranged) with *bhikkhuniya* being taken as a mistake for *bhikkhuniyo* and as such *tasāṅketa* does not make any sense and was,

69. Cf. S I 32.13: *so ca sabbadādo hoti | yo dadāti upassayaṃ* (the one who gives an abode, is the giver of all).

70. Mil 212; Si 290–291: *puna ca paraṃ vihāre vijjamāne bhikkhuniyo byattasaṅketā bhavissanti sulabhaṃ dassanaṃ dassanakāmānaṃ aniketā duddassanā bhavissatīti*.

71. Horner 1969, 3 and n.2; Nolot 1995, 348 and n.225.

72. Handout notes from a workshop in Nagoya, Japan in 2009.

73. Si 261–262: *puna ca paraṃ mahārāja vihāre vijjamāne bahū bhikkhū viyattā bhavissanti sulabhaṃ dassanakāmānaṃ aniketā duddasā bhavissantīti*.

74. Handout notes from a workshop in Japan, an email from von Hinüber to Skilling dated 6 Sept 2009.

Table 7 Nuns with permanent addresses or many skilled monks.^a

CA	<i>vihāre</i>	<i>vijjamāne</i>	<i>bahū</i>	<i>bhikkhū</i>	<i>viyattā</i>	<i>bhavissanti</i>
CL	<i>vihāre</i>	<i>vijjamāne</i>		<i>bhikkhuniyo</i>	<i>byattasaṃketā</i>	<i>bhavissanti</i>
CKT (1)	<i>vihāre</i>	<i>vijjamāne</i>	<i>bahū</i>	<i>bhikkhū</i>	<i>viyattā</i>	<i>bhavissanti</i>
CKT (2)	<i>vihāre</i>	<i>vijjamāne</i>		<i>bhikkhuniyo</i>	<i>byattasaṃketā</i>	<i>bhavissanti</i>
L ^{LH}	<i>vihāre</i>	<i>vijjamāne</i>		<i>bhikkhuniyo</i>	<i>byattasaṃketā</i>	<i>bhavissanti</i>
Si (1)	<i>vihāre</i>	<i>vijjamāne</i>	<i>bahū</i>	<i>bhikkhū</i>	<i>viyattā</i>	<i>bhavissanti</i>
Si (2)	<i>vihāre</i>	<i>vijjamāne</i>		<i>bhikkhuniyo</i>	<i>byattasaṃketā</i>	<i>bhavissanti</i>
Mil	<i>vihāre</i>	<i>vijjamāne</i>		<i>bhikkhuniyo</i>	<i>byattasaṃketā</i>	<i>bhavissanti</i>

a. CA = NL6133, ti-v.4; CL = SN1, tai-r.2; CKT (1) = NL333, ne-r.5; CKT (2) = NL333, pho-r.5;

L^{LH} = Image 55, folio 34.3; Si (1) 261–262; Si (2) 290–291; Mil 212.

consequently “corrected” to *bya-tta*-. Even if there is no corruption, the variant still exists between *bhikkhu-niyatasāṅketa* and *bahū bhikkhū viyattā*.

In terms of transmission, Table 7 shows that the textual characteristic of CA and CL are also found in CKT. Both are also included in Si. Another point is that the textual tradition of CL seems to be in agreement with L^{LH} and Mil.

b) Frequency of meals the Buddha partakes in a day

Cognate dialogues:

1. “A Question on the [Superiority of] One who is Devoted to Begging” (*yācayogapañha*) (Si 268–269)
2. “A Question on a Few Illnesses of the Blessed One” (*bhagavato appābādhapañha*) (Si 291–293; Mil 215–217)

This pair of cognate dialogues concerns a dilemma that emerges due to two statements made by the Buddha: that his body is unsurpassed (*anuttara*), and by declaring his disciple, Bakkula, as the chief in having few illnesses (*appābādhā*). The dilemma concerns which of the two has better health. These two cognates differ in several ways, but I would like to draw attention to the following variants with respect to just one detail—their accounts of the number of times the Buddha eats in a day.

One of the explanations given by Nāgasena to the dilemma is that when it comes to certain aspects, external to the Dharma (*bāhirāṇaṃ āgamānaṃ*), some disciples of the Buddha surpassed him in those aspects. For example, those who practice eating only one meal a day (*ekāsānika*), even for the sake of their life, would not partake of a second meal. In this respect, they surpassed the Buddha who would eat twice or even three times a day.⁷⁵ It is rather surprising that the Buddha partook of a second or even a third meal. In the *suttas*, the Buddha has repeatedly said “O Monks, I partake of a meal at one session [in a day]” (*ahaṃ kho, bhikkhave, ekāsanabhojanaṃ bhuñjāmi*) and he also encourages his monks to do the same (*etha tumhe pi bhikkhave ekāsanabhojanaṃ bhuñjatha*) (M I 124 and M I 437). Therefore, it is unlikely

75. Mil 216: *santi kho pana mahārāja bhagavato sāvakā ekāsānikā, te jīvitahe tu pi dutiyaṃ bhojanaṃ na bhuñjanti, bhagavā pana mahārāja dutiyaṃ-pi yāva tatiyaṃ-pi bhojanaṃ bhuñjati ye te mahārāja bhikkhū ekāsānikā te tena aṅgena atirekā.*

Table 8 Frequency of meals in a day.^a

CA	<i>bhagavā</i>	<i>mahārāja dutiyaṃ</i>	<i>chāte</i>	<i>na bhuñjati</i>
CL	<i>bhagavā pana pana</i>	<i>mahārāja dutiyampi</i>		<i>bhojanaṃ na bhuñjati</i>
CKT (1)	<i>bhagavā</i>	<i>mahārāja dutiyaṃ</i>	<i>chāte</i>	<i>na bhuñjati</i>
CKT (2)	<i>bhagavā pana</i>	<i>mahārāja dutiyampi</i>	<i>tatiyampi</i>	<i>bhojanaṃ bhuñjati</i>
L ^{LH}	<i>bhagavā pana</i>	<i>mahārāja dutiyaṃ pi yāva tatiyaṃ pi</i>		<i>bhojanaṃ bhuñjati</i>
Si (1)	<i>bhagavā pana</i>	<i>mahārāja dutiyaṃ</i>	<i>chātena</i>	<i>bhuñjati</i>
Si (2)	<i>bhagavā pana</i>	<i>mahārāja dutiyampi</i>	<i>tatiyampi</i>	<i>bhojanaṃ bhuñjati</i>
Mil	<i>bhagavā pana</i>	<i>mahārāja dutiyampi yāva tatiyampi</i>		<i>bhojanaṃ bhuñjati</i>

a. CA = NL6133, to-r.4; CL = SN1, tau-v.2; CKT (1) = NL333, pi-r.1; CKT (2) = NL333, phau-v.3; L^{LH} = Image 54, folio 39.4; Si (1) 269; Si (2) 292; Mil 216.

that Nāgasena or the author(s) of the *Milindapañha* were unaware of this. Despite the fact that there are clauses in the *Vinaya* rules that declare an *out-of-turn meal* (*paramparabhojana*) as a non-offence—for example, at a time of giving or making robes (Vin IV 77; Horner trans. 1940, 319–320)—the reading in this dialogue looks like a general statement than exceptions to the rules. However, if we turn to the manuscripts in Central Siam, they differ considerably. Table 8 listed the variants among the different recensions.

The Buddha's partaking of meals up to three times in a day is reflected in L^{LH}, Mil and one of the cognates, Si (2). The other cognate, Si (1), even has the unthinkable: that the Buddha has a second meal due to hunger (*chātena bhuñjati*). This could not be accurate, as in the “Discourse of Heirs of Dhamma” (*Dhammadāyādasutta*) in the *Middle Length Discourses* (*Majjhima-Nikāya*), the Buddha praised one of his two disciples, who has refused to take the left over alms-food and passed the night and day hungry and weak compared to another who took it (M I 13.27–28). This point was even quoted by Nāgasena later on (Si 131; Mil 242).

On the contrary, if we interpret the text in CA and CKT (1) slightly differently from Si (1), we get an entirely dissimilar meaning: “O King, [though] the Blessed One does not partake of a second meal in the case of hunger, those disciples who practice eating only one meal a day (*ekāsanika*) surpassed him in this respect.”⁷⁶ Here, we read the text as *chāte na bhuñjati* (does not eat in the case of hunger) instead of *chātena bhuñjati* (eats due to hunger). The editor of Si may have opted for *chātena bhuñjati* to be in agreement with the other cognate, or it could be a typo in the printed edition. Furthermore, in CL, the text becomes less ambiguous: “but, on the contrary, O King, though the Buddha does not partake a second meal, those who practice eating only one meal a day surpassed him in this respect.” Hence, the readings in the Siamese manuscripts seems to be in accord with the *suttas*.

76. Strictly eating only once a day (*ekāsanika*) is one of the thirteen ascetic practices (*dhutaṅga*) (Vin V 193; Mil 359). In this dialogue, monks would not partake a second meal even to save their lives (*jivitaṭhetu*). Therefore, this extreme practice is regarded as a quality that surpasses one who just does not eat a second meal.

We do not know where earlier readings on the Buddha eating a second or third meal come from.⁷⁷ It could very well be due to errors in the textual editing process. Perhaps the text was *bhagavā pana na mahārāja dutiyampi tatiyampi bhojanam bhuñjati* and the negation, *na*, after *pana* was deleted by the redactor thinking it was a dit-tograph.⁷⁸ Moreover, the redactor might have reasoned out that if some disciples who eat a single meal a day are better than the Buddha in this regard, the Buddha should be eating more than once a day; therefore, eliminating the *na* does make sense. Nonetheless, here we observe another comparison between an extreme practice versus a non-extreme one.⁷⁹

In terms of transmission, we notice that the *chāte na bhuñjati* has moved from CA (Ayutthaya) to CKT (Bangkok) and later into Si. The CKT is most likely from where Si was derived. The textual tradition of Mil seems to be closer to L^{LH} than CL, suggesting they might come from a further common ancestor (recension).

The two examples above show that the CKT has selected readings from CL as well. Moreover, there are differences in details between the cognate dialogues which could probably be the reason why the CKT redactors chose to include both rather than feeling forced to choose one. I believe the editors of Si may have faced the same dilemma; nevertheless, they have reduced the number of cognate dialogues from seven pairs in CKT to three in Si.

Dialogues found only in the CKT recension

There are two dialogues found in Part II–III of CKT that are not found in the Ayutthaya period CA and CL:⁸⁰

1. “A Question on One who has Gone to the World Beyond: whether he goes in a Form that is Blue or Yellow or Another [Colour]” (*paralokagatanīla-pītādivaṇṇagatapāṇha*) (Si 117–120; CKT: NL333, ghai-r.4)
2. “A Question on Connection to the Mother’s Womb [in a New Existence]” (*mātukucchipaṭisaṇḍhi-pāṇha*) (Si 120–121; CKT: NL333, ghau-v.4)

At this moment, we do not know where these two dialogues come from. They are also found in CA manuscripts which were copied in the Rattanakosin period, for example, NL8307, NL3964 and NL4595. They could have either descended from a further recension of CA, no longer represented by the Ayutthaya period manuscripts extant today, or they could be the results of editing efforts from the post-Ayutthaya period. They are also not found in Mil and the *Chatṭhasaṅgīti* edition as well as NBS. The other possibility is that they could come from another regional Pāli composition.

77. Horner trans. 1969, 9 and n. 2.

78. Skilling: email 2 September 2020.

79. See n.76.

80. The edited texts (from five manuscripts) of these two dialogues, and their translations, will be published at a later date.

Question on going to the world beyond

The first dialogue addresses an important yet delicate issue in Buddhist philosophy—what is transferred from life to life. It starts with King Milinda asking whether a person going to the world beyond (*paralokam gacchati*)⁸¹ goes there as a blue, yellow or red shape, or as a radiance or as an apparition of an elephant, a horse or a chariot.⁸² He continues with further questions: if the five aggregates (*pañcakkhandā*) do not go to the world beyond, and if the form of these aggregates is not made (or caused by something) (*akatavidha*), then is there no cycle of rebirth (*saṃsāra*)?; Does the aggregate of feeling or perception travel to the world beyond?⁸³ Nāgasena replies to each of these questions with similes. The similes employ the following imagery: can one see any form or colour in a speech when it is traveling from one's mouth to another's ears? Will the tip of a plant grown from Sāli rice sown into the ground grow upwards, as a form not made (or grow naturally without anything causing it to be so)?⁸⁴; Could a man, who has his hands and feet cut off perceive himself the same when he is reborn into another world?⁸⁵ Does the flame of one lamp transfer to another, or does it arise as a form not made?⁸⁶ Lastly, if the eye of a reflected image in a mirror is removed, does one become a one-eyed person? The dialogue then concludes with the emphasis that even though the five aggregates do not travel to the world beyond, rebirth is dependent on them; through actions either wholesome or unwholesome, a being is connected to the next mother's womb.

Question on the connection to the mother's womb

This question is somewhat related to the "Question on Going to the World Beyond". It is about when a being is connected (*paṭisandhāyati*) to the next mother's womb, assuming transmigration in some kind of form, or a radiance or an apparition, through which door the being enters the mother's womb. Nāgasena gives a simile of the thought of a treasure chest and shows that the mind does not act through a door to get to the treasure inside the chest. Similarly, a being is connected to the mother's womb not by going through a door.

The presence of these two dialogues in the study of the *Milindapañha* transmission history further shows not all the Milinda-Nāgasena textual traditions survive in one particular (Pāli) recension. As in this case, the two dialogues are found only in CA copied in the Rattanakosin era and CKT, but not in CL.

81. *Paraloka* here will be taken to mean another realm to which a being transmigrates after death.

82. Chariot, cf. the simile of the designation (*paññatti*) of a person (*puggala*) (Mil 25).

83. Cf. consciousness (*viññāṇa*) (M I 256).

84. May have some resemblance to the *Rice Seedling Sūtra* (the *Śālitamba Sūtra*): see Reat 1993, 38 and 58–61.

85. Cf. the king's question to Makkhali Gosāla who propounded the theory that there are no deeds that are skilled and unskilled, there is no fruit, no result of deeds well done and badly done. Si 9; Mil 5; Horner trans. 1963, 7.

86. Cf. Si 97–98; Mil 71; Horner trans. 1963, 97–98.

The textual tradition of CKT remains pretty stable throughout its manuscript transmission up to the Fifth Reign (1868–1910). The other “royal” editions or their copies are also kept at the National Library. It has been a tradition for the Thai monarchs to sponsor the copying of the *Tripitaka*, as a means to acquire merit for the good of humanity and to preserve the teaching of the Buddha for future generations.⁸⁷

Textual lineages

The dissimilarities among these recensions raise the question of whether this is a feature of Pāli literature transmitted in Siam. It is known that textual instability and innovation are characteristics of the Siamese textual tradition, like the presence of numerous “non-classical” Pāli literature or the recasting of texts. For example, the *Mahāvamsa* is recast as the *Vaṃsamālīnī*.⁸⁸ However, the differences in textual characteristics among the Siamese *Milindapañha* recensions are subtler and they do not constitute entirely recast versions, yet they contain important differences in style and detail. Nevertheless, there are already two known recasts of the *Milindapañha*. One is seen embedded in the *Vaṃsamālīnī*. In chapter thirteen of the *Vaṃsamālīnī*, the *rājavaṃsādīkathā pariccheda*, there is a section on the *Milindapañha*, composed entirely in verses or *gāthā*, 733 of them.⁸⁹ The other one is the *Milindapañha Saṅkhepa* which comes in three *phūk* instead of the usual fifteen to twenty *phūk*; with some manuscripts having a title labelled as the *Milindapañha Vitthāra* (the *Extended or Extensive Milindapañha*). Despite the CKT recension seeming to be a bit “extended” compared to other recensions, the extra content is partly due to the presence of cognate dialogues and dialogues only found in this recension. The term *vitthāra* here is probably used to differentiate it from the *saṅkhepa* version (Ooi 2021, 179).

As we have seen, CKT is the result of intertextual influences among the various *Milindapañha* recensions. However, the dissimilarities between CA and CL may go beyond intertextual influence. At present, CA is not found outside Central Siam, hence, we do not know whether CA is specifically a characteristic of the Siam textual tradition per se, as currently there is no comparative study on the difference between the Siamese textual tradition and the others, even for root texts belonging to the *Tripitaka*.

Thus, this opens up another set of questions: where could CA and CL possibly be descended from, and what could be their textual history? Again, we do not have any definite evidence to point to any particular textual community or transmission route. However, it is worth exploring a few probabilities, which might help to add small pieces to the jigsaw puzzle, towards the resolution of the entire picture later.

87. See the English translation of the preface of the first printed royal edition of the *Tripitaka* by the king of Siam, published in 1894–95 (Chalmers 1898, 3–4).

88. For more examples of non-classical texts and the characteristic of Pali literature of Siam, see Skilling 2014, 355–363.

89. See Nedis Rucirarucana 1989, 301–354. Nedis’ work includes a translation of this section in Thai.

The Lineage of CA

For the CA recension, one likelihood is that it is a descendant of a text of Sukhothai Buddhist provenance which in turn received the text, perhaps, from Rāmaññadesa.⁹⁰ Even though the lineage of Theravaṃsa communities in Rāmaññadesa can be traced back to Ceylon, they may have developed into independent institutions with their own textual tradition. As such, when Ayutthaya integrated Sukhothai, it inherited the latter's textual tradition as well. However, in order to strengthen this argument, further philological and orthographical studies need to be done to compare the CA recension with other known works of Sukhothai or of Rāmaññadesa provenance. It is also possible that the text was brought directly from Rāmaññadesa into Central Siam by the migrating Mon from the sixteenth to the early nineteenth centuries, and it was then transliterated into Khom script. Unfortunately, a Mon-script CA is yet to be discovered.⁹¹ The Mon-script Pāli *Milindapañha* of Wat Paramayyikāvāsa, dated 1808, is a CKT recension and it is believed to be transliterated from a Khom-script manuscript.

The next probability is to revisit the earlier question as to whether CA is a feature of the Siamese textual tradition. I agree with Skilling that we should not view the textual tradition of Siam as a mere import (Skilling 2009, 117). After the formation of the Siamese kingdoms in the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries, their textual communities were active and dynamic in nature. They may have adapted received texts to local social and cultural conditions, and thus would have evolved their own characteristics.

In summary, the origin of the CA recension cannot be nailed down at this moment. We know it is different from CL which, in my opinion, has a more direct transmission from Ceylon.

The Lineage of CL

There are three probabilities regarding the origin and lineage of CL. First, it is the result of direct interaction between the Lan Na Kingdom and Ceylon between the fourteenth to fifteenth centuries. Second, it is a descendent from the Haripuñjaya Kingdom which is centred at Lamphun, thus the name for this recension. Thirdly, as monks travel frequently, it could be a direct transmission to Central Siam from Ceylon.

Khom CL manuscripts are found in Central Siam, albeit only a few manuscripts where the CL textual tradition is found in the form of hybrid recensions. There is also one in Southern Thailand (see above). The textual tradition of CL is in agreement with L^{LI}, Mil and the *Chaṭṭhasaṅgīti* edition. As we know, both Mil and the *Chaṭṭhasaṅgīti* edition are primarily based on Sinhalese traditions.⁹² Given the pos-

90. The use of Rāmaññadesa here refers specifically to a geographical region, Lower Burma, covering the coastal area to the Gulf of Martaban and the towns or cities in the area including Thaton, Martaban, and even Pegu.

91. A survey done in 2012 by the Southeast Asian Regional Centre for Archaeology and Fine Arts on Mon manuscripts kept at five temples in Bangkok found no *Milindapañha* text.

92. The *Chaṭṭhasaṅgīti* edition comes with a colophon that states: "[This text] which was caused to

sibility that CL and L^{LI} could share a common hyparchetype, due to their close proximity, and the latter link to Ceylon (von Hinüber 1988, 116), the CL recension is probably the result of a direct transmission from Ceylon during the active interchange between Lan Na and Ceylon in the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries, and it was then transmitted to Central Siam.

On the other hand, when Lan Na took over the Kingdom of Haripuñjaya in the late thirteenth century, it continued to maintain Lamphun as the centre for Buddhist learning (Sarasawadee Ongsakul 2005, 35). One clue that Lan Na may have preserved the reading of older and better manuscripts comes from a lacuna in the Sinhalese manuscripts, used in Trenckner's edition, which was supplemented from a Siamese manuscript. The Sinhalese manuscripts used for the printed edition have a marginal note that says *siyaṃdesato ānītapotthakato issatthassa pañhato paṭṭhāya pariyosānavacanāni gahetvā likhitan'ti jānitabbaṃ* (Mil v-vi; Godakumbura 1980, 50) ("It should be known, from the "[simile of the] archer [issatha]" up to the closing words, has been written using a manuscript brought from the land of Siam)."⁹³

Unfortunately, it is difficult based on this partial and short passage of the "archer" to determine the recension that was brought back from Siam. Moreover, the particular SN1 image of the CL recension which has this lacuna is missing from the collection. Nevertheless, if we take into account one short phrase in the dialogue⁹⁴ which is found in Mil as well as in L^{LI} but absent in CA,⁹⁵ it seems that the supplement is of the CL recension. If that is so, given that the textual traditions of CL, L^{LI} and those Sinhalese manuscripts are somewhat in agreement, the Siamese manuscript may have preserved a reading that the Sinhalese manuscripts lost. Trenckner is of the opinion that it is a spurious supplement (Trenckner 1880, v).⁹⁶ It could be so. However, Rhys Davids argues that the author(s) of the *Milindapañha* would not end the text in the middle of a dialogue and without a concluding paragraph. As such, he reckons that the Siamese manuscript may have transmitted the reading of older and better manuscripts than those in Ceylon, where the last folio(s) may have been lost (Rhys Davids 1890, xxiv). If this is the case, CL could have been in the Lan

be written (*likhetvā*) by the Mahāthera named Doṇi, who lived in the City of Doṇi in Laṅkā, was well-arranged [and] according to what was heard." Vijitha Kumara is of the opinion that the City of Doṇi could either be a previous Buddhist site, Tonigala, situated at the District of Puttalam of North Eastern province of Ceylon or the old capital city of Dambadeniya, also known as Jambudonī, which is currently located at the District of Kurunegala. Based on the construction of the verses at the colophon, he thinks the latter is most likely the case. He estimated that the manuscript might have been copied between the sixteenth and early eighteenth centuries: email 15 November 2020.

93. Mil 418.21–420. Perhaps it is referring to the text that is in a smaller font size beginning in page 418 up until the end in the edition published by Williams and Norgate.
94. *Kathaṃ mahārāja yoginā yogāvacarena imasmim kāye upāsītābbaṃ* (and how, O King, must the yogi, the earnest student of yoga, while he is in this body, practise?): L^{LI}, image 92, folio 54.4; Mil: 418; Horner trans. 1969, 303.
95. CA for examples: NL6133, hai-r.3 and NL4596, hai-r.4.
96. Von Hinüber also deduced that the "lost" supplement could not have been written earlier than the sixteenth century (von Hinüber 1987, 116–117).

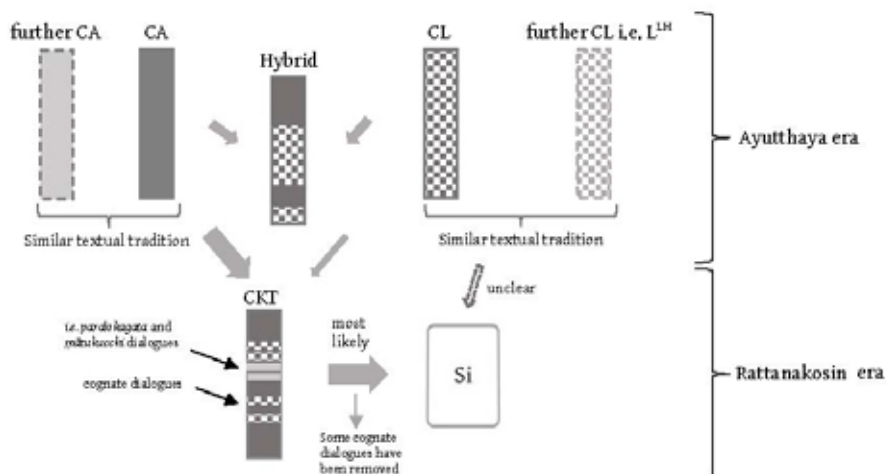


Figure 4 The revision of the *Milindapañha* to CKT.

Na Kingdom earlier, even up to the time of the Haripuñjaya Kingdom. Furthermore, the name of the recension itself points towards that as a possibility.

The Lineage of CKT

As discussed above, the CKT recension is derived from CA with selected readings from CL plus other materials (Figure 4). The other materials could either be from a further CA recension which is no longer extant to us today or other Pāli compositions. In my opinion, it is most likely the former, because the dialogues that are absent in the Ayutthaya period CA recension are found in witnesses to the CA recension copied in the Rattanakosin era. The CKT was probably the result of a revision exercise held during the First Reign of the Rattanakosin era, or a little earlier, as evidenced by manuscript NL333. They are extant in Khom and Mon scripts. Si is most likely derived from CKT recension, but it is unclear whether the editor(s) of Si has consulted other printed editions available at that time, for example *Mil* published in 1880, while Si in 1923.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the evidence points to the emergence of Milinda-Nāgasena texts around the beginning of the Common Era. By the fourth or fifth centuries CE, these texts were already in circulation in most parts of North West India, Ceylon and China. We have seen earlier that there are Milinda-Nāgasena dialogues preserved in a Chinese *avadāna*, the Sanskrit *Abhidharmakośabhāṣya* and fragments of a Gāndhāri text that are not represented by either the Pāli *Milindapañha* or the Chinese NBS. This leads me to believe that the Milinda-Nāgasena tradition was much wider than is usually thought to be the case, and once circulated in different textual communities regardless of school.

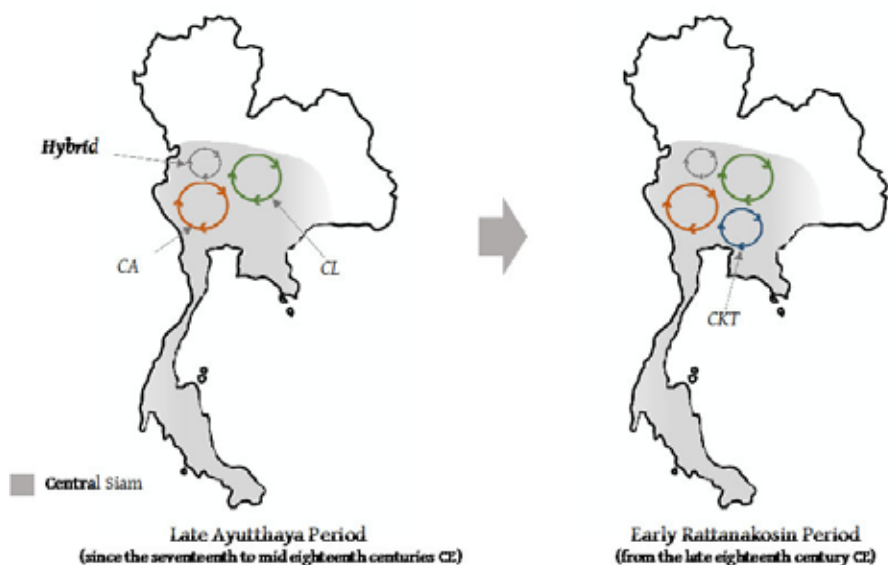


Figure 5 Recensions of the Siamese *Milindapañha* circulated in Ayutthaya and Rattanakosin eras

The examination of the Siamese Pāli recensions, especially CA, has also shown considerable difference in textual tradition compared to another Pāli recension, CL, which has a textual lineage somewhat similar to that of Mil and in extension to the Ceylonese textual tradition. Both the CA and CL recensions were already in circulation in Central Siam from at least the seventeenth century (Figure 5). Even though the origin of their textual lineages cannot be precisely determined, they are surely the results of efforts made by different textual communities, either belonging to different schools or different lineages of the same school that preserve and transmit these texts.

Efforts in the transmission process seem to have included editing the text for consistency with respect to particular textual traditions, or restoring it if part of the text was lost. The presence of hybrid recensions could be the result of this quick restoration exercise by collating loose manuscripts and putting them together in the same bundle, a practice that continues today.⁹⁷ From time to time, there were revision councils, or *saṅgīti*, to revise and improve on Buddhist texts. The Siamese Ninth Buddhist Council, held in 1788 in Bangkok under a new Chakri dynasty may have resulted, directly or indirectly, in a new recension of the *Milindapañha*, CKT. These findings show that the shape of a textual tradition involved in the preservation and transmission of a text is dynamic, fluid and entangled. At least in the case

97. For example NL4606 has two sets of manuscripts in one bundle and NL6133 has four sets.

of the *Milindapañha* in Siam. This dynamic fluidity most likely reflects a function of the textual community that preserved it.

Appendix I

A provisional chronology of the *Milindapañha* [not extant or without clear evidence]

2nd c. BCE	Sāgala	[Milinda-Nāgasena dialogues purportedly took place.]
1st c. BCE–1st c. CE	Gandhāra	[The dialogues were likely first written down, most likely in Gāndhārī.]
1st to 3rd CE?	Gandhāra	A few fragments of a Gāndhārī text reference to Nāgasena.
2nd c. CE	China	Translation into Chinese, the * <i>Nāgasena Bhikṣu Sūtra</i> (<i>Nàxiān bīqiū jīng</i> 那先比丘經).
3rd c. CE	Ceylon	[Citations of the dialogues in the <i>Mahatṭhakathā</i> of the Mahāvihāra fraternity in Sinhala(?).]
4th–5th c. CE	Kashmir/ North India	Citation of a single dialogue by Vasubandhu in the <i>Abhidharmakośabhāṣya</i> in Sanskrit.
5th c. CE	Ceylon	Citations of the text by Buddhaghosa in the <i>Samantapāsādikā</i> and <i>Visuddhimagga</i> . Citations are also found in other commentaries to the <i>Nikāyas</i> .
	China	Several dialogues are translated in a Chinese <i>avadāna</i> collection, <i>Zábǎozàng jīng</i> (雜寶藏鏡).
10th c. CE	Burma	Nāgasena named in a votive tablet, north of Rangoon.
11th c. CE	North India	King Milinda referred to by Kṣemendra in <i>Bodhisattvāvadāna-Kalpalatā</i> .
1113 CE	Burma	Reference to Nāgasena on a votive tablet in Pagan.
1223 CE	Burma	Donation of the <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscript: Pagan Inscription of 1223 CE.
13th–14th c. CE	Ceylon/Siam	Quoted in the <i>Sārasaṅgaha</i> .
14th c. CE	Sukhothai	Reference as source by King Lithai for the <i>Traibhūmikathā</i> .
1442 CE	Burma	Donation of the <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscript: Pagan Inscription of 1442 CE.
1495 CE	North Thailand	Lan Na-script Pāli <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscript, kept at Wat Lai Hin (L ¹⁴), Lampang. The oldest <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscript extant.
15th c. CE	North Thailand	The <i>Milinda-Ṭikā</i> and the <i>Milindapañhagāthā</i> in <i>Vaṃsamālinī</i> .

16th–17th c. CE	Ceylon	Sinhala-script Pāli <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscript, kept at Copenhagen. Trenckner's manuscript B.
1637 CE	Southern Laos	Tham Lao-script Pāli <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscript, kept at Vat Nyuttithammathalalam in Champassak.
1686–1755 CE ^a	Central Thailand	Several Khom-script Ayutthaya Pāli <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscripts of different recensions, kept at the National Library, Bangkok; Trinity College; Bibliothèque nationale de France, and Wat Samuh Nimit in Chaiya District, Surat Thani Province.
1758 CE	Burma	Burmese-script Pāli <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscript, kept at Bagaya Monastery, south of Mandalay.
1782–1809 CE ^b	Central Thailand	NL333 a copy of the royal edition of the Ninth Council. A new recension, <i>Chabap Krung Thep</i> . Several other Khom and Mon-script manuscripts, kept at the National Library.
1808 CE	Central Thailand	Mon-script Pāli <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscript, kept at Wat Paramayyikāvāsa.
1824–1910 CE ^c	Central Thailand	Khom-script Pāli <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscripts, royal and non-royal copies, kept at the National Library.
1948 CE	Burma	Printed edition of the <i>Milindapañhā-Aṭṭhakathā</i> by Thaton Mingun Zetawun Sayadaw, Rangoon.

Notes:

a. The late Ayutthaya period.

b. The First Reign.

c. Third to Fifth Reign.

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Abbreviations

BCE	Before Common Era (543 – BCE = BE)
BE	Buddhist Era (BE – 543 = CE)
CE	Common Era (CE + 543 = BE)
DPPN	Dictionary of Pāli Proper Names, edited by G. P. Malalasekera. 1937–1938. London: John Murray for the Indian Government.
Mil	<i>The Milindapañho: Being Dialogues between King Milinda and the Buddhist Sage Nagasena</i> , edited by V. Trenckner. 1880. Edinburgh: William and Norgate.
NA	not available
NL	A prefix for manuscript found at the National Library of Thailand. For example, NL6133 means manuscript of the National Library, code 6133.
phūk	fascicle / fascicles of palm-leaf folios. a <i>phūk</i> generally has twenty-four written folios on both side.
-r	<i>recto</i> , the alphabets preceding this is the palm-leaf folio number.
-v	<i>verso</i> , the alphabets preceding this is the palm-leaf folio number.

Primary texts

As	<i>Atthasālinī: Buddhaghosa's Commentary on the Dhammasaṅgaṇi</i> , ed. Edward Müller. 1979. London: PTS.
CA	Pāli <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscript(s) of <i>Chabap Ayutthaya</i> (Ayutthaya recension).
CKT	Pāli <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscript(s) of <i>Chabap Krung Thep</i> (<i>Krung Thep</i> or Bangkok recension).
CL	Pāli <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscript(s) of <i>Chabap Lumpun</i> (Lumphun recension).
CST4	<i>Milindapañhapāli</i> , Chaṭṭha Saṅgāyāna Tipiṭaka, version 4.
Ja	<i>The Jātaka together with its commentary</i> , ed. V. Fausbøll. 1877–1896. London: PTS.
L ^{LH}	Pāli <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscript of Wat Lai Hin, Lampang, Northern Thailand. Images of the Preservation of Northern Thai Manuscripts Project (PNTMP code 030102024-00, www.lannamanuscripts.net).
M	<i>Majjhima-nikāya</i> , edited by V. Trenckner and R. Chalmers. 1887–1902. London: PTS.
Mil	<i>The Milindapañho: Being Dialogues between King Milinda and the Buddhist Sage Nagasena</i> , edited by V. Trenckner. 1880. Edinburgh: William and Norgate.
Mil-ṭ	<i>Milinda-ṭīkā</i> , edited by Padmanabh S. Jaini. 1961. London: PTS.
NBS	那先比丘經 (* <i>Nāgasena Bhikṣu Sūtra</i>). 大正新脩大藏經 Taishō shinshū daizōkyō, Vol 32, No. 1670B.
Sāra	<i>Sārasaṅgaha</i> , ed. Genjun H. Sasaki. 1992. Oxford: PTS.
Si	<i>Milindapañhā</i> , ed. Cattasalla Thera <i>et al.</i> 1923. Bangkok: Mahāmakūṭa-rājavidyālaya. / มิลินทปัญหา: จดดสกลเถรณ ฌมมปาโมกเขน มกุฏขตติยารามวาสิ นนา โสธิตา, ๒๔๖๖. สยามมกุฎราช ราชธานี: มหามกุฏราชวิทยาลัยเยน ปกาสิตา.
Sn	<i>Suttanipāta</i> , edited by D. Andersen and H. Smith. 1913. London: PTS.
SN1	Pāli <i>Milindapañha</i> manuscript No. 1 of Wat Samuh Nimit in Chaiya District, Surat Thani Province, Southern Thailand.

- Sp *Samantapāsādikā: Buddhaghosa's Commentary on the Vinaya Piṭaka*, edited by J. Takakusu and Makoto Nagai. 1924–47. London: PTS.
- T *Taishō shinshū daizōkyō*, edited by Takakusu, J. and K. Watanabe *et al.* 1924–1932. (Mainland Buddhist Association edition, Hebei)
- Vibh-a *Sammohavinodanī (Vibhaṅga-aṭṭhakathā)*, edited by A. P. Buddhadatta. 1923. London: PTS.
- Vin *Vinaya-piṭaka*, edited by H. Oldenberg. 1879–1883. London: PTS.

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